

Are we all doing too much?

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF COGNITIVE LOAD



presented by:

Cristan Massey

Head of Service Management @ Pearson

Vice Chair @ ITSMF UK

WHO AM I?

How many hats do I wear?



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Management @
Pearson Education

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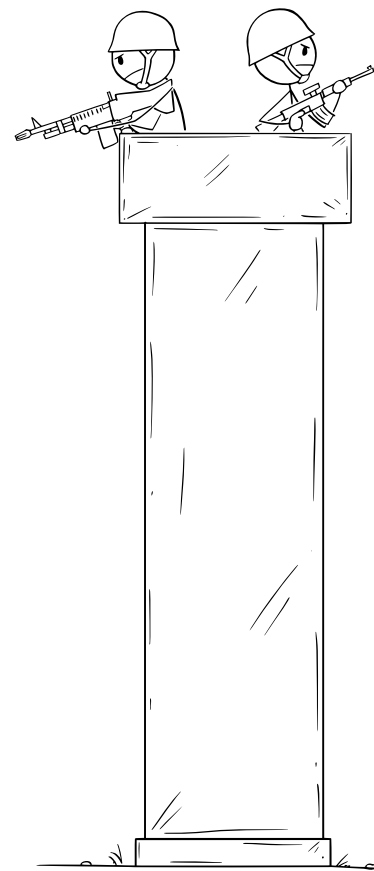
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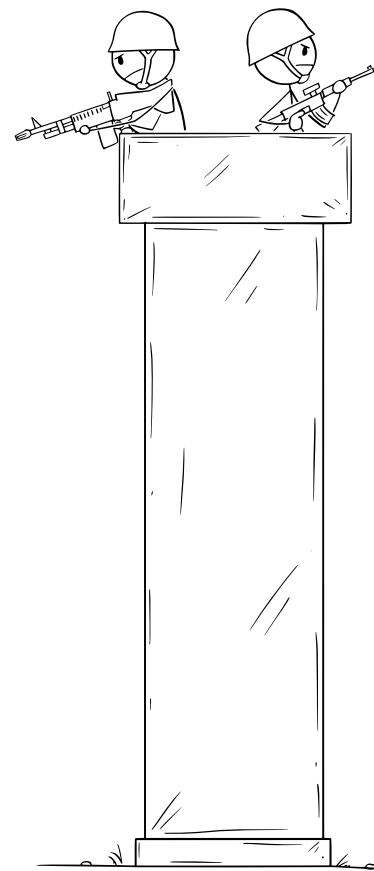
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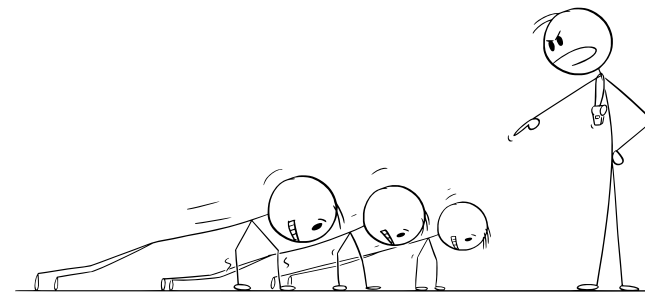
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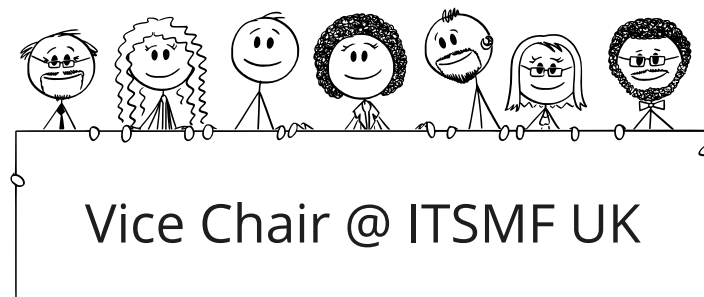
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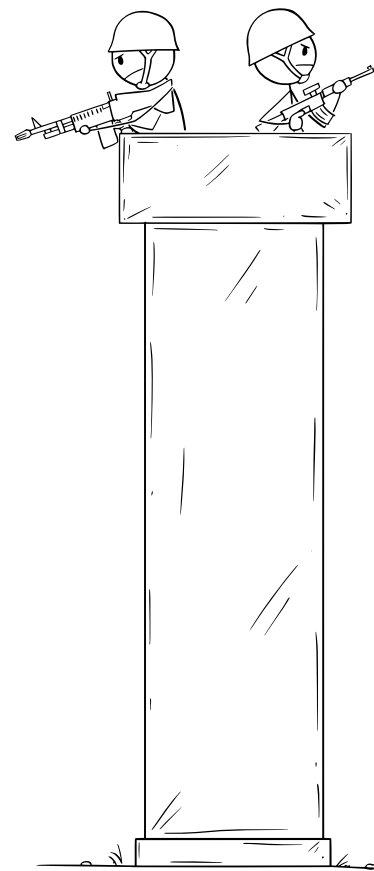
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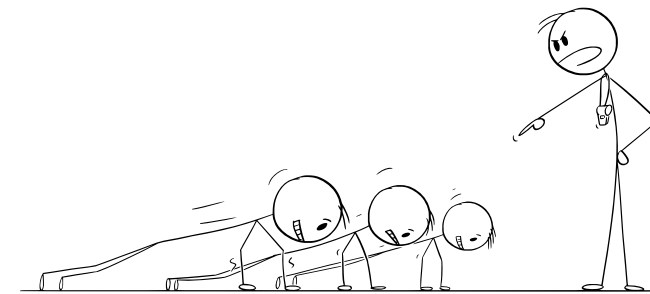
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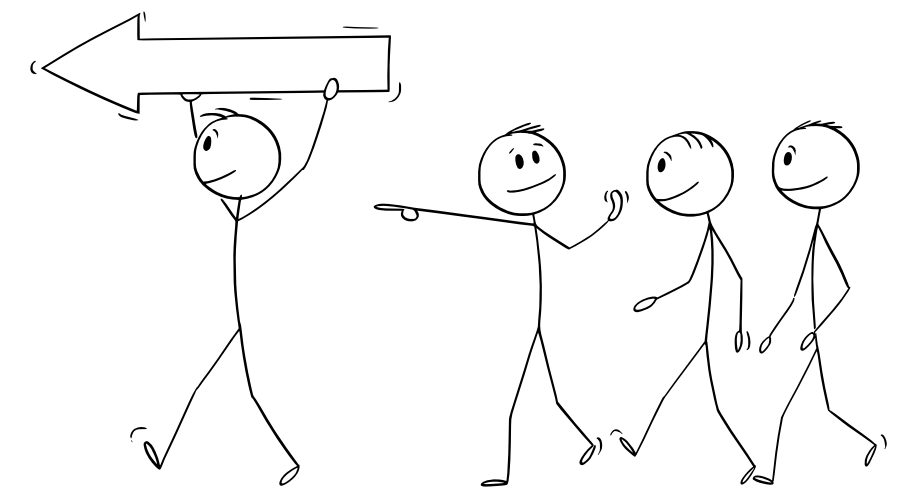
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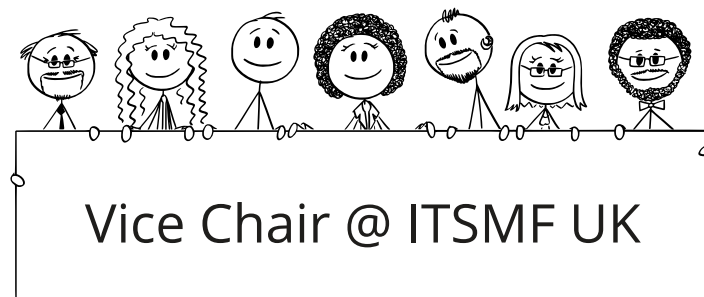
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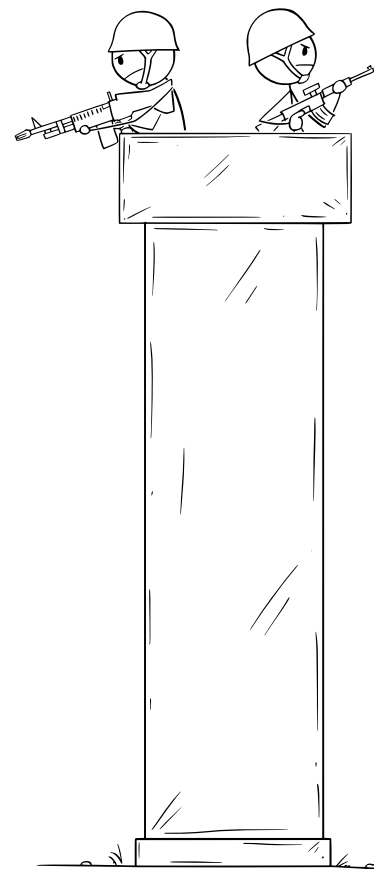
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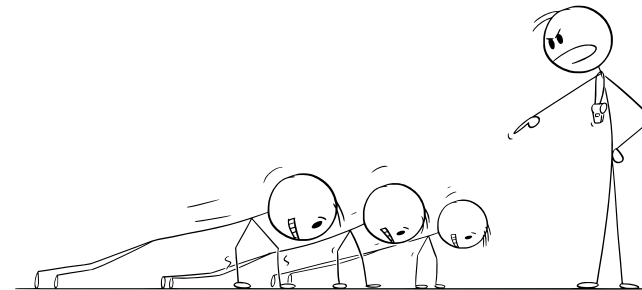
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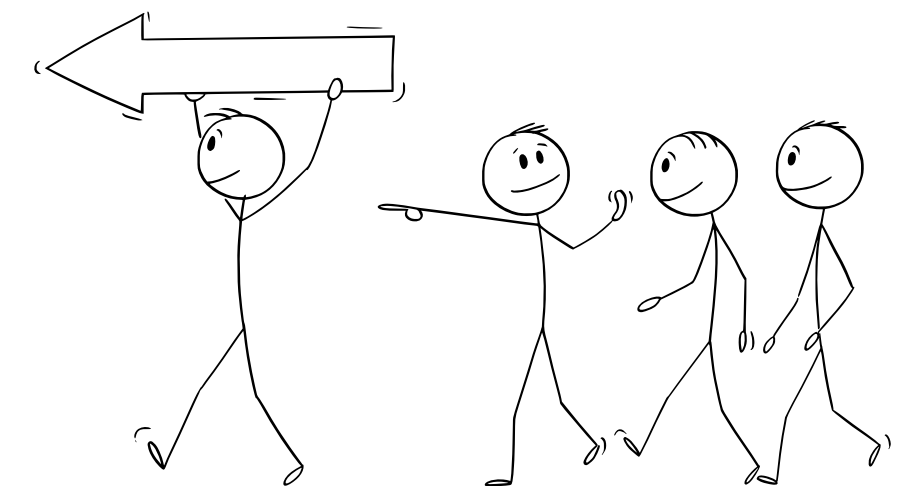
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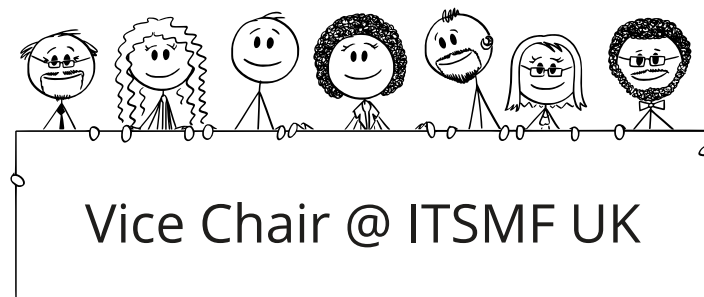
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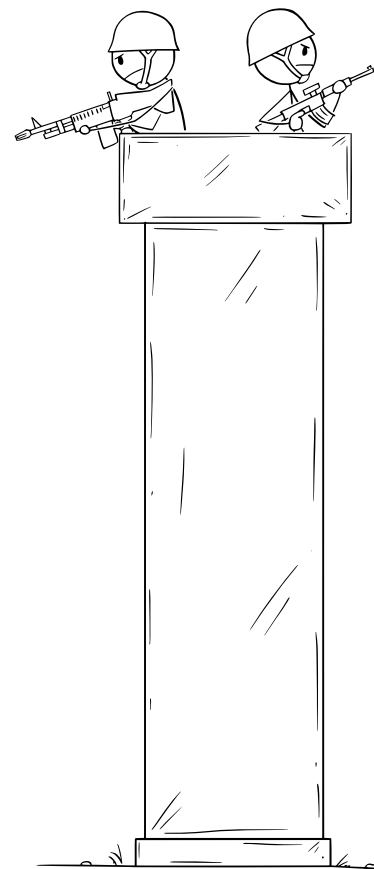
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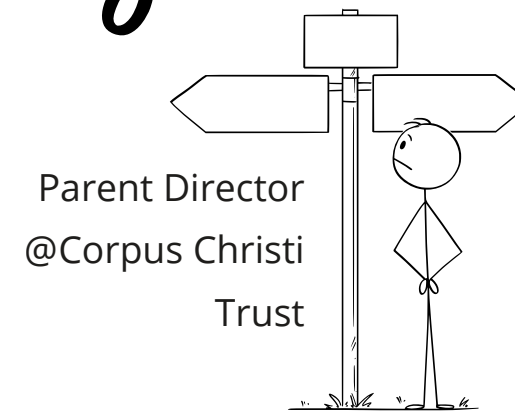
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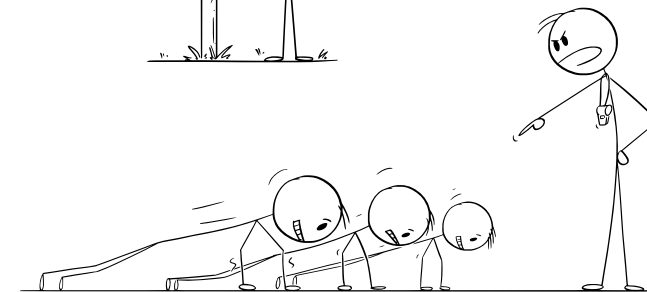
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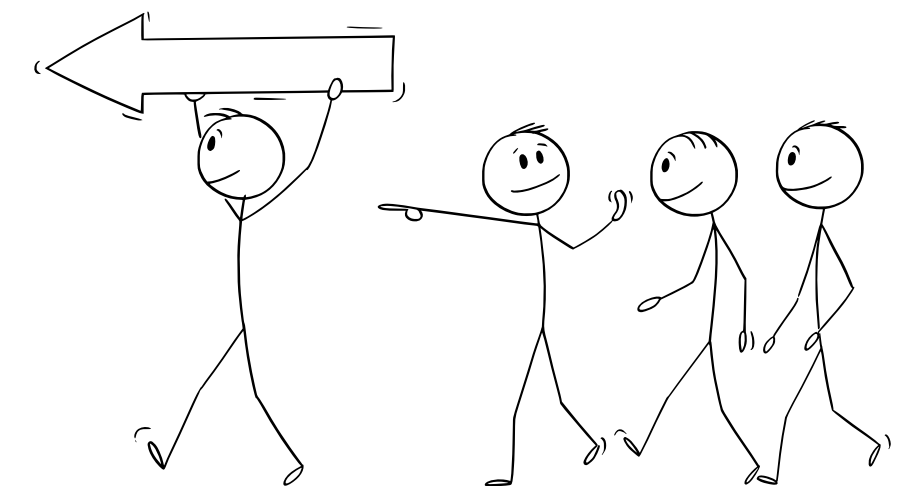
Parent Director
@Corpus Christi
Trust



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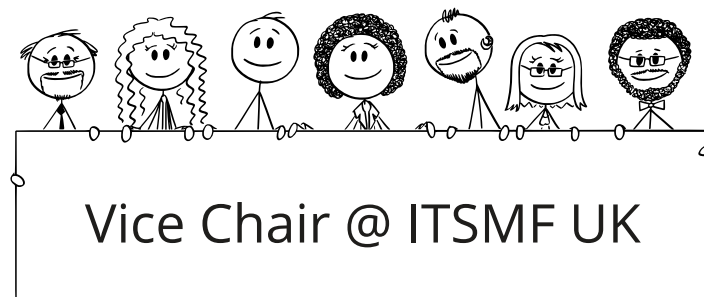
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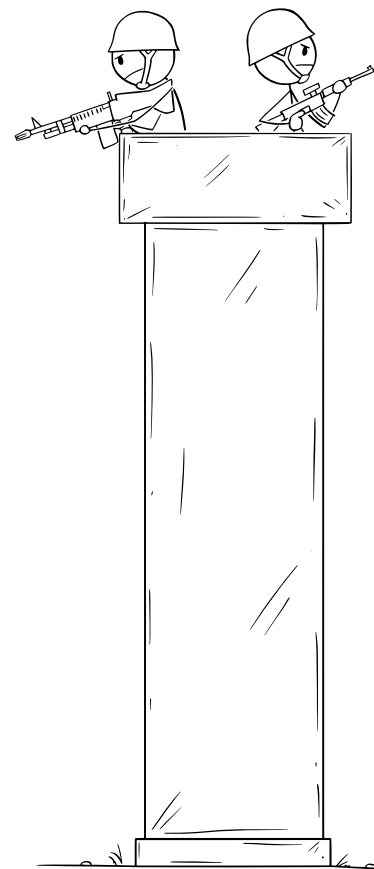
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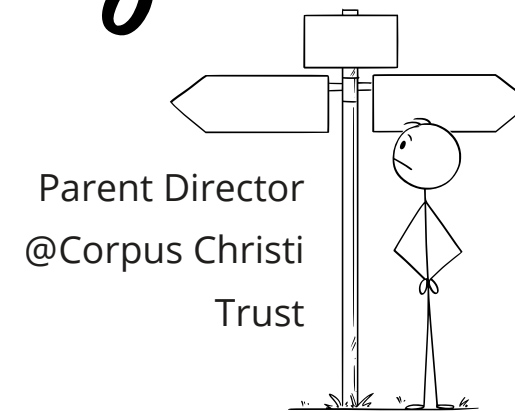
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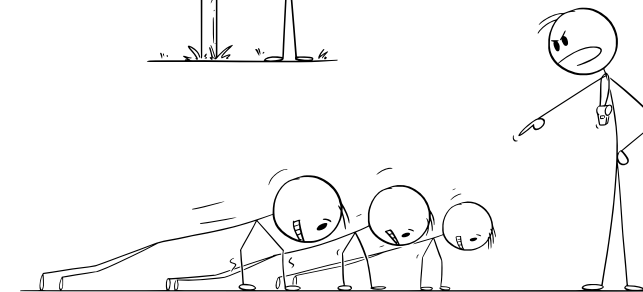
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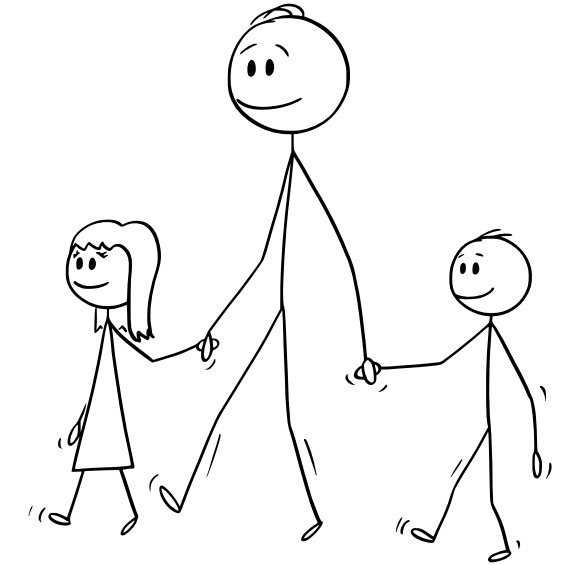
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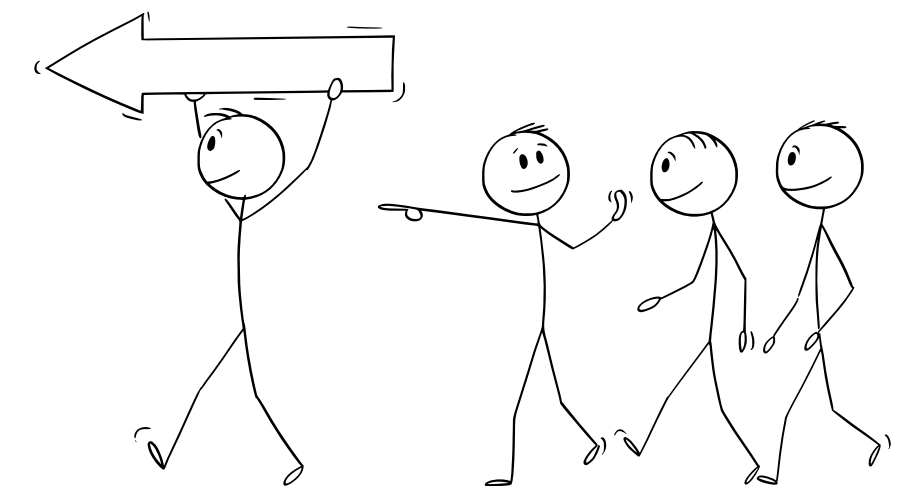
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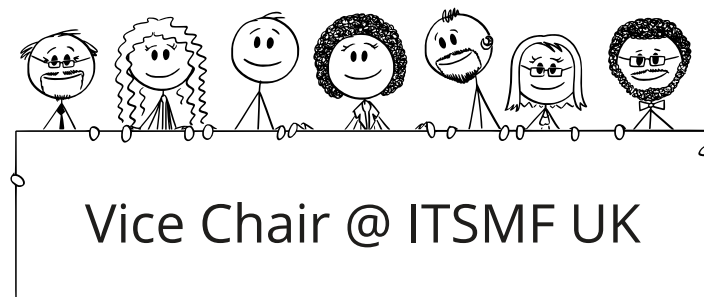
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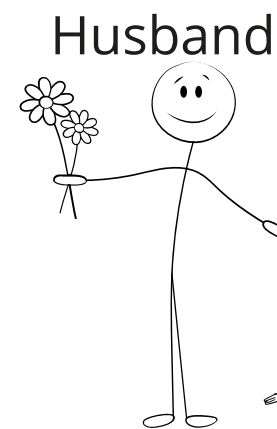
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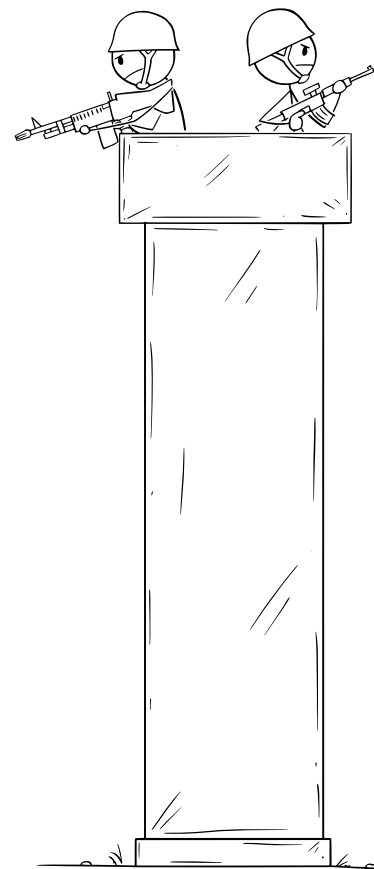
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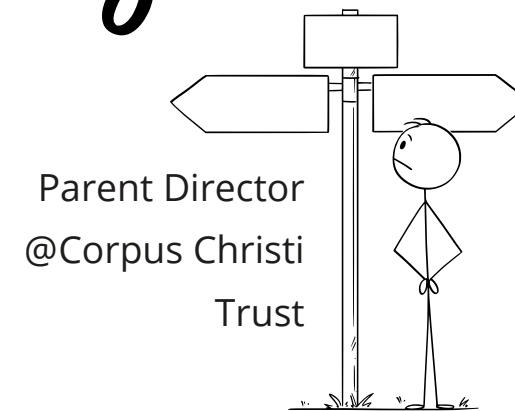
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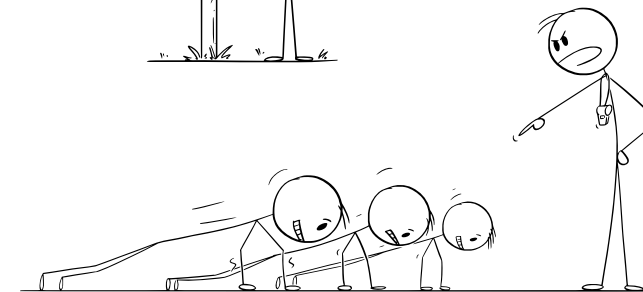
Husband



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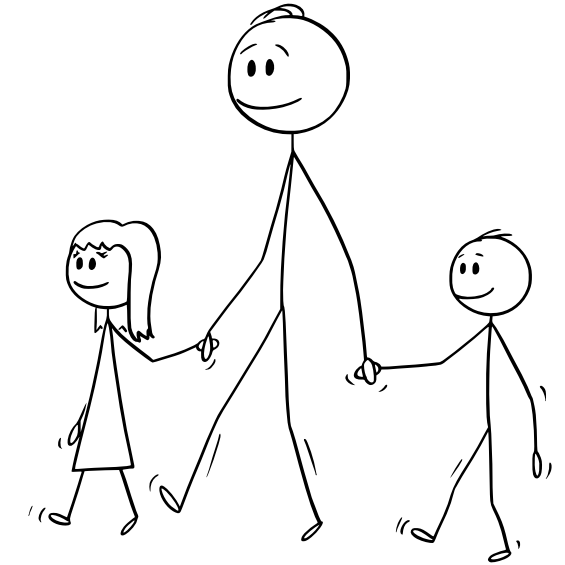
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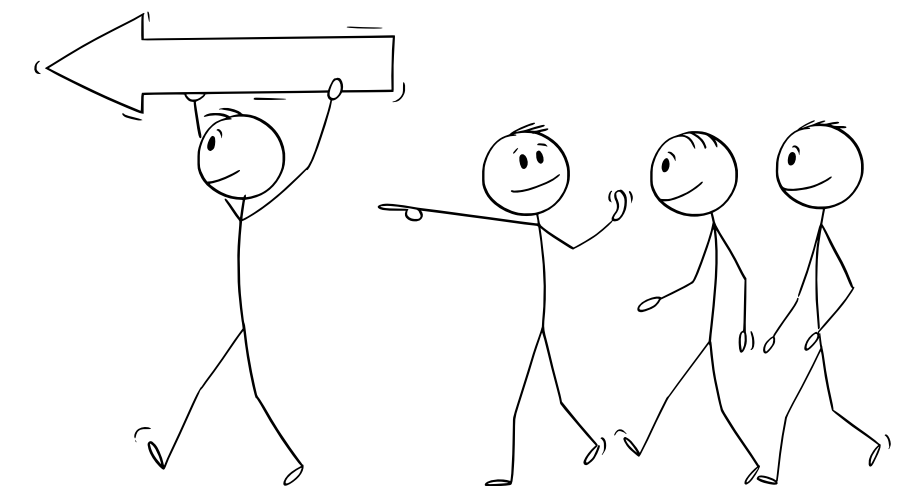
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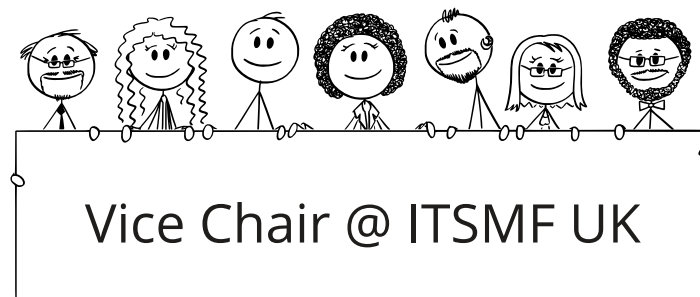
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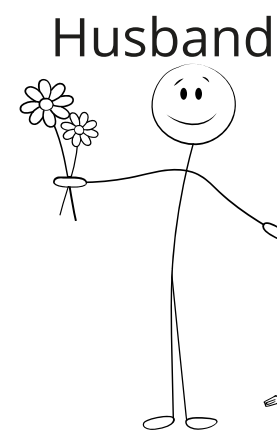
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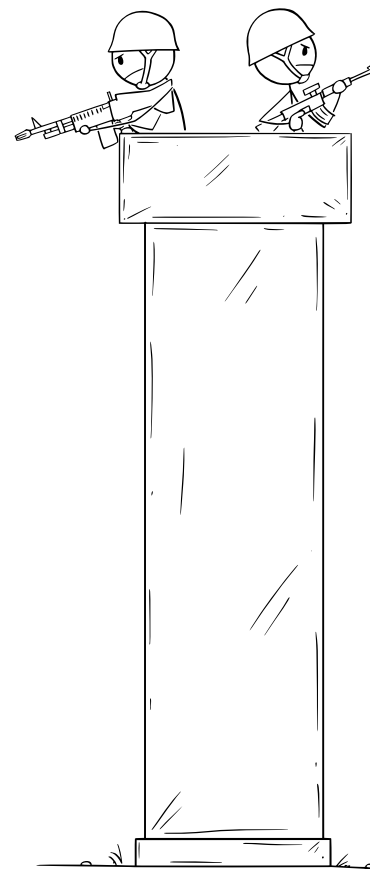
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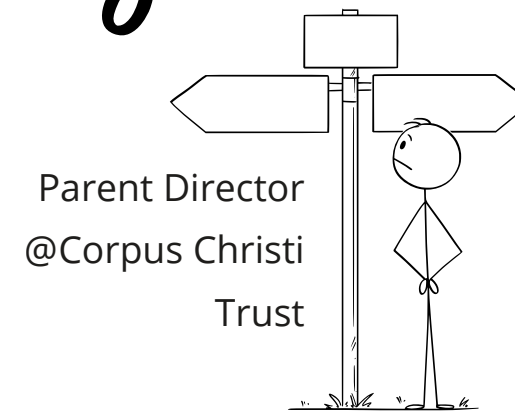
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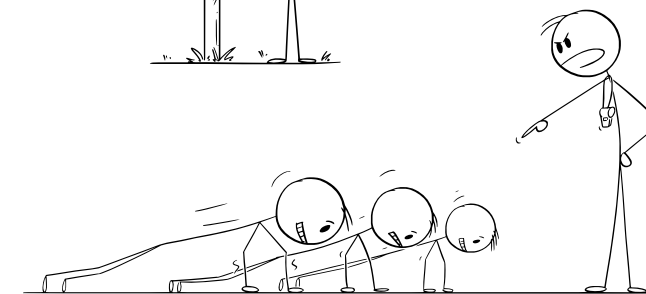
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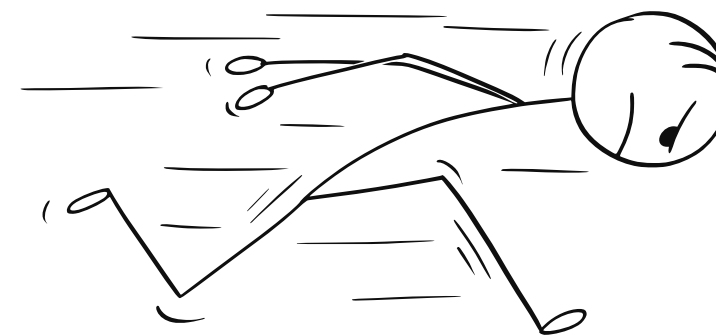
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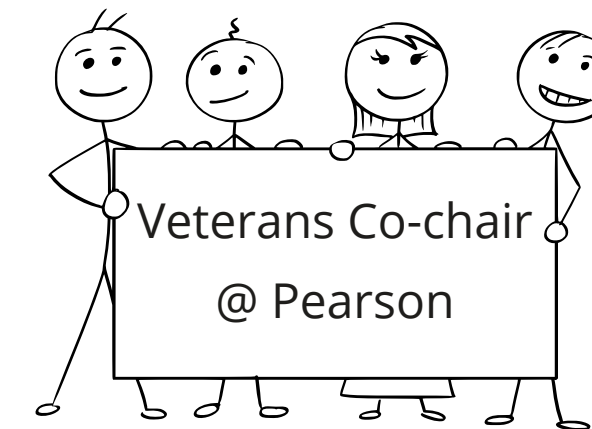
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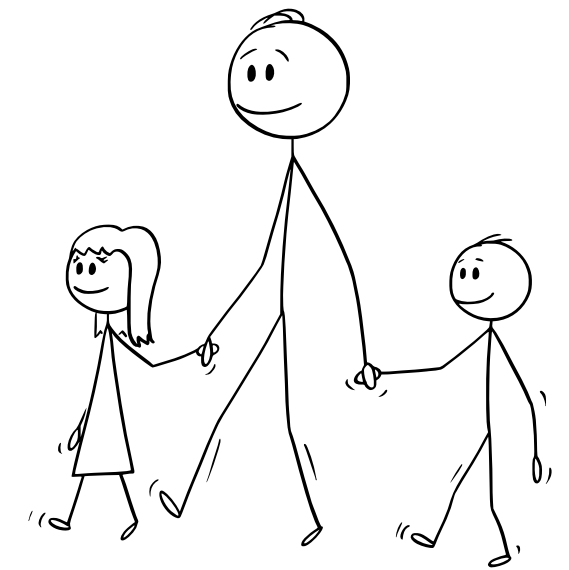
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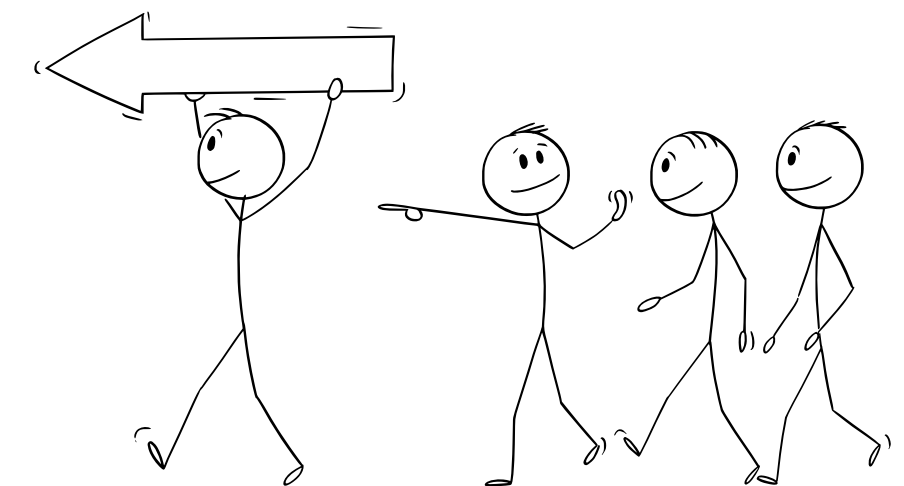
Runner



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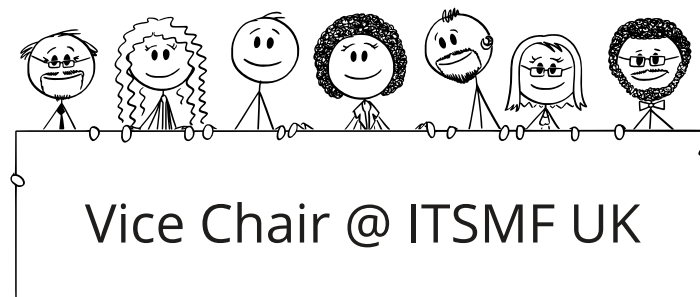
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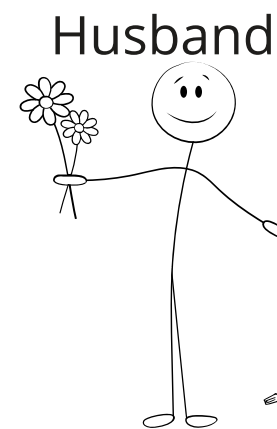
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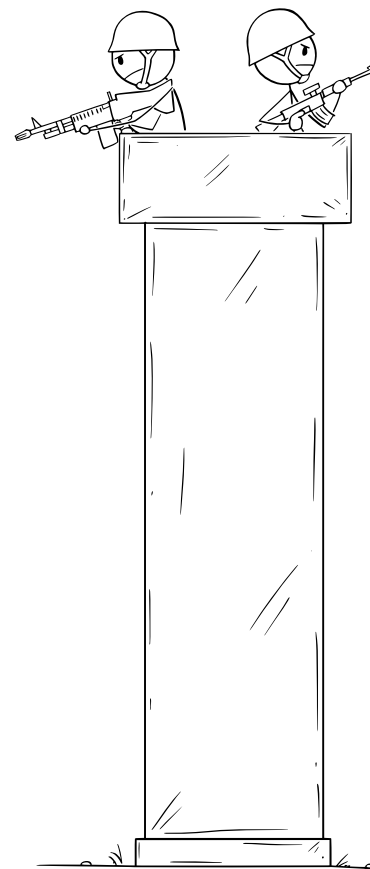
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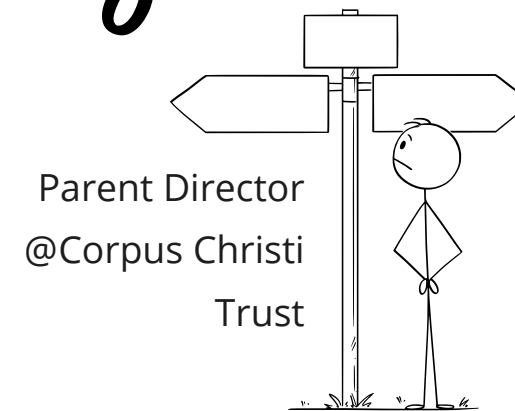
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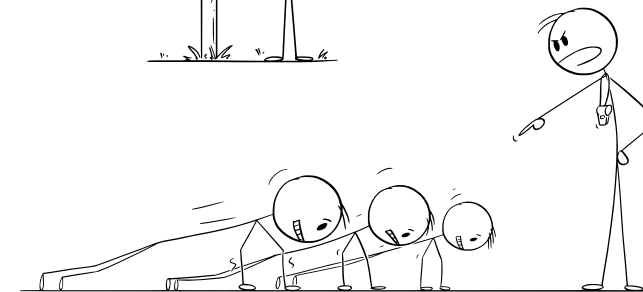
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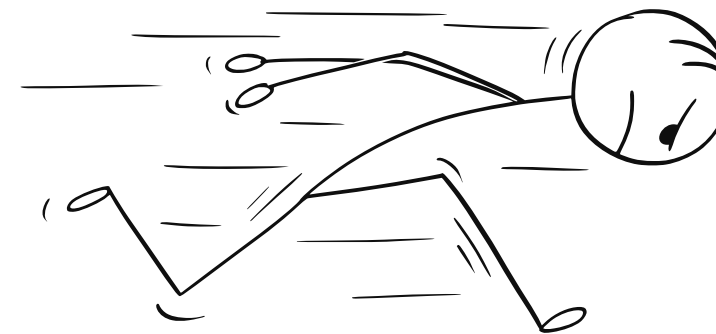
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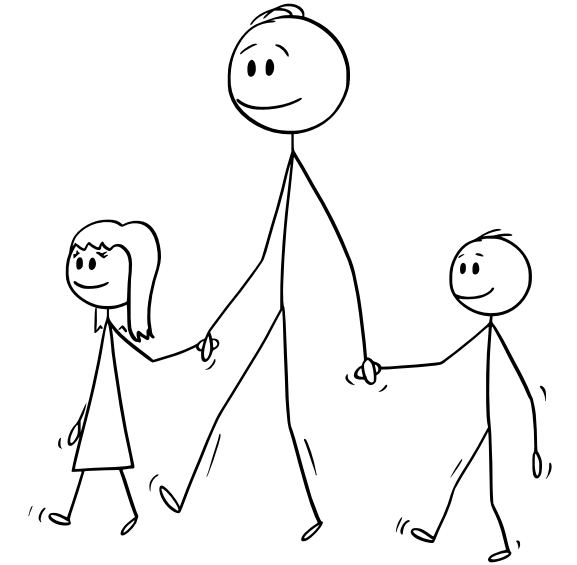
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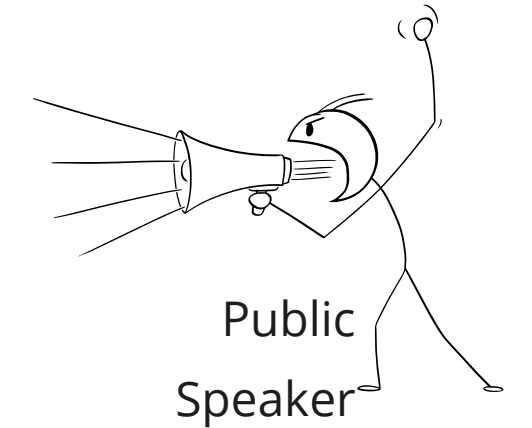
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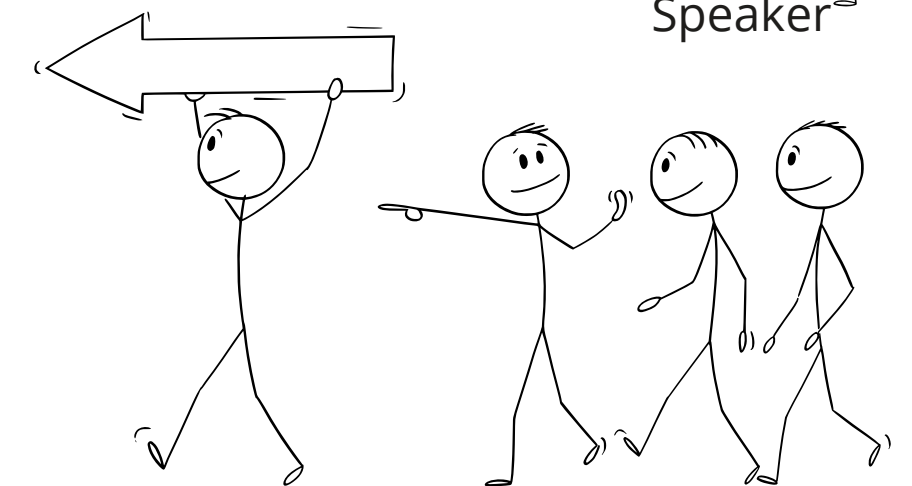
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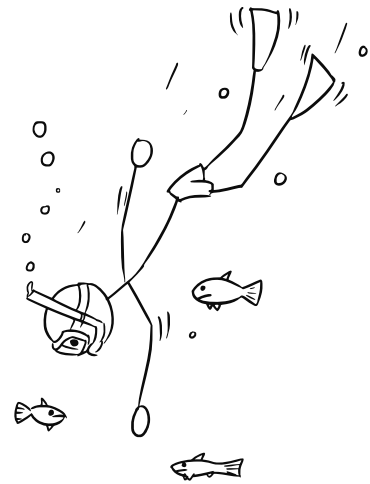
Public
Speaker



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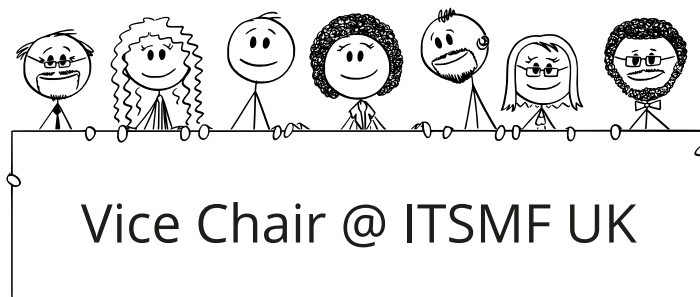
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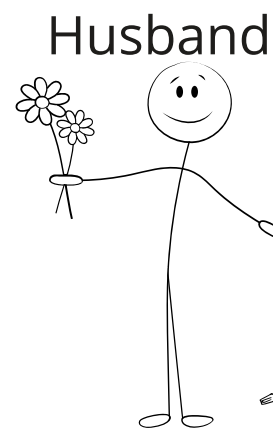
BSAC Advanced
Ocean Diver



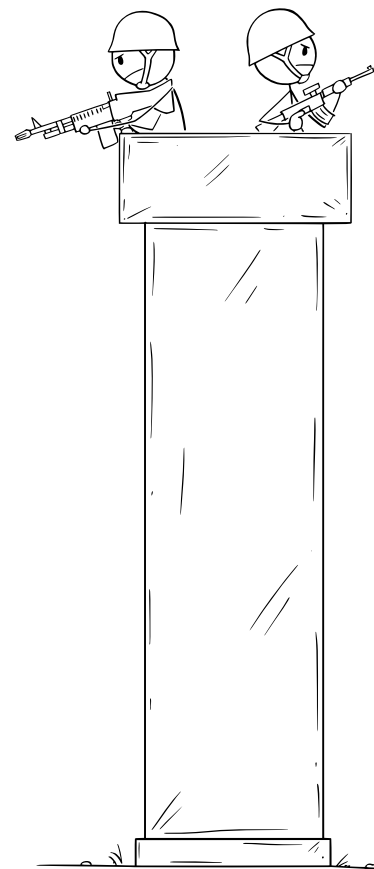
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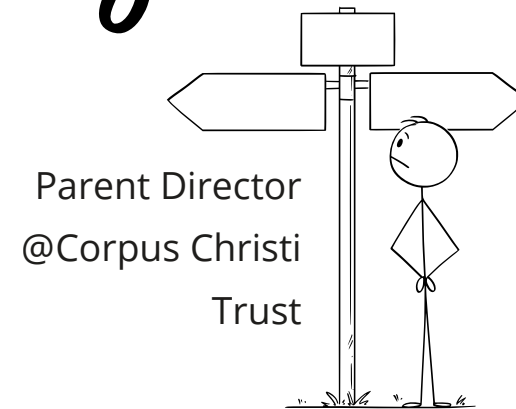
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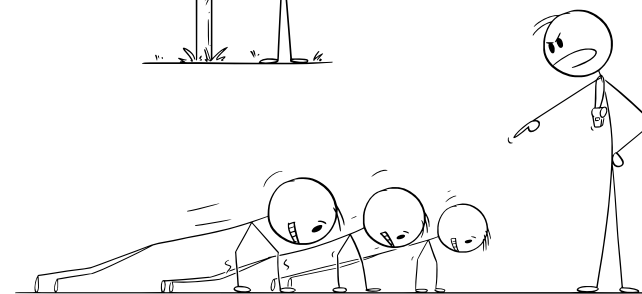
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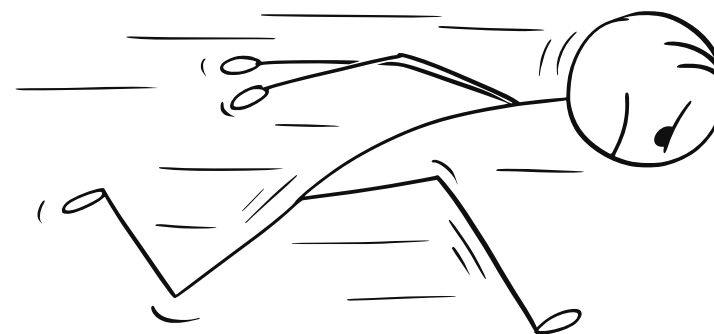
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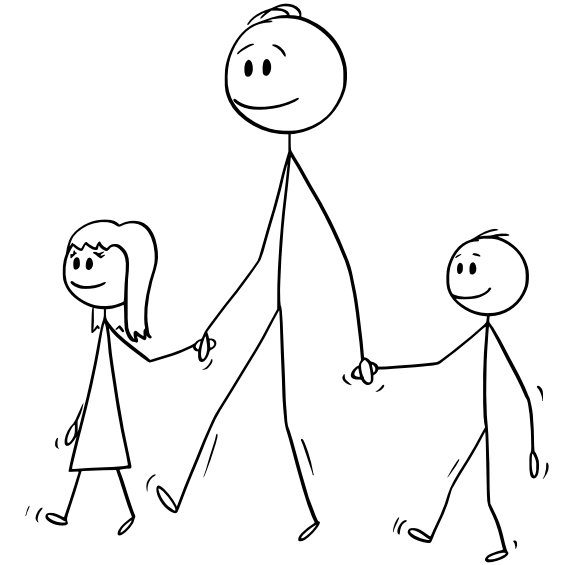
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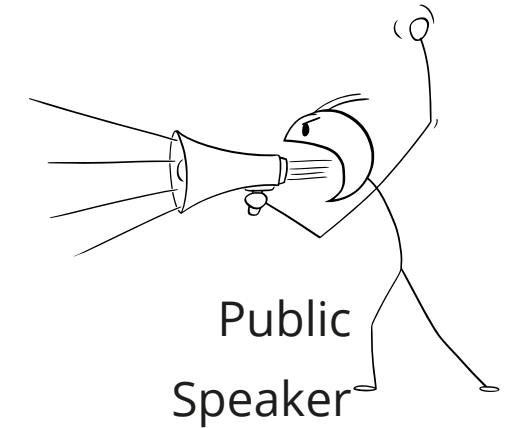
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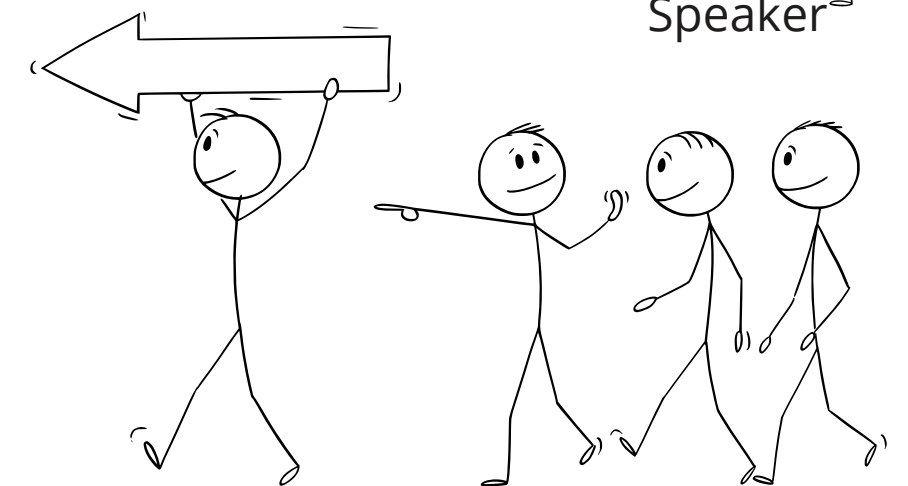
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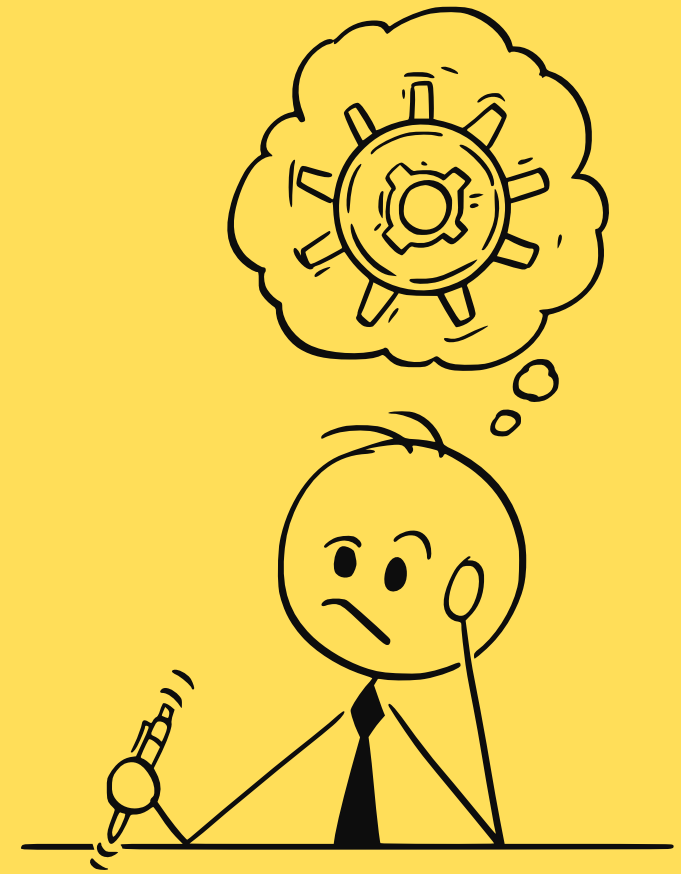
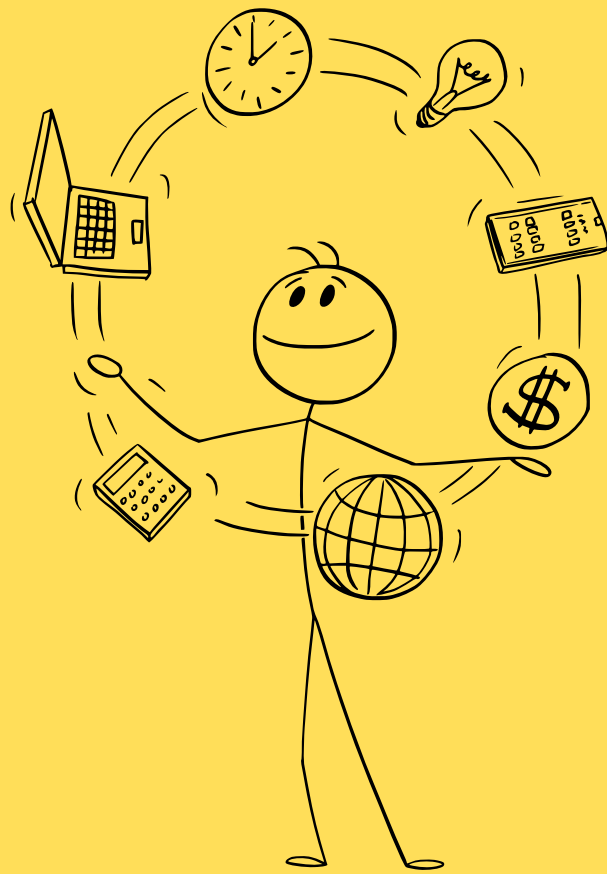


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ARE WE ALL DOING TOO MUCH?

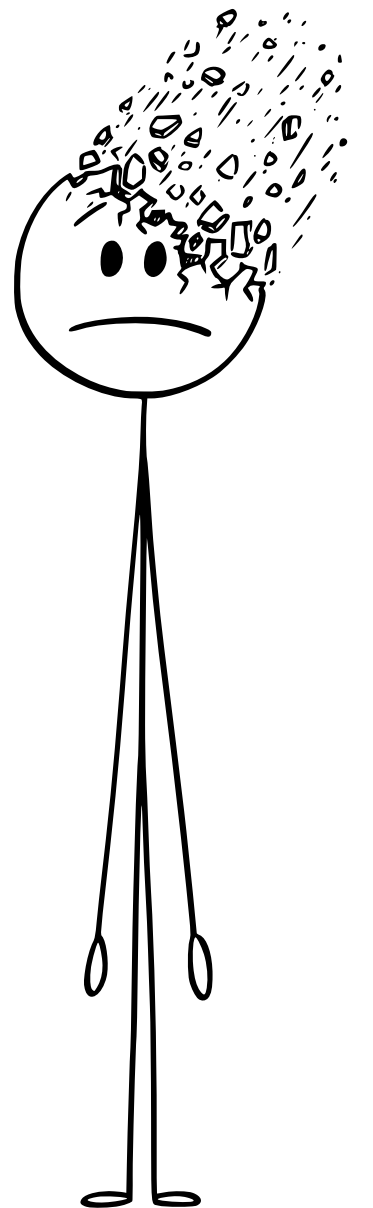


Cognitive Load Theory

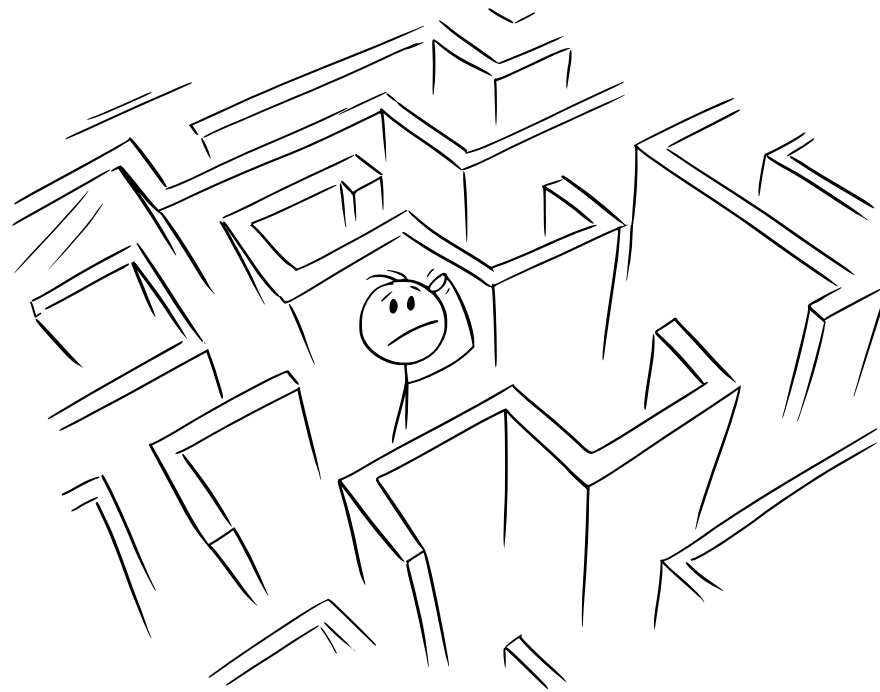
Cognitive Load Theory (CLT) was coined by John Sweller in 1988.

The theory proposes that our working **memory is limited**. We can only juggle so many things at once. When we go over the limit, **performance drops, errors rise**, and **stress** creeps in.

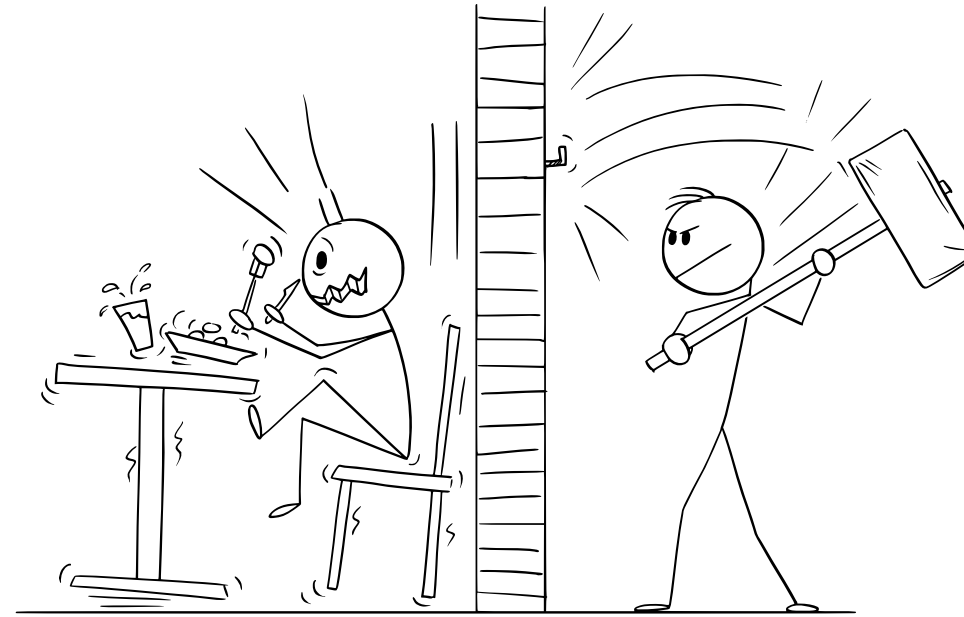
Think of your brain like a phone with too many apps open. Eventually, the battery drains and everything slows down.



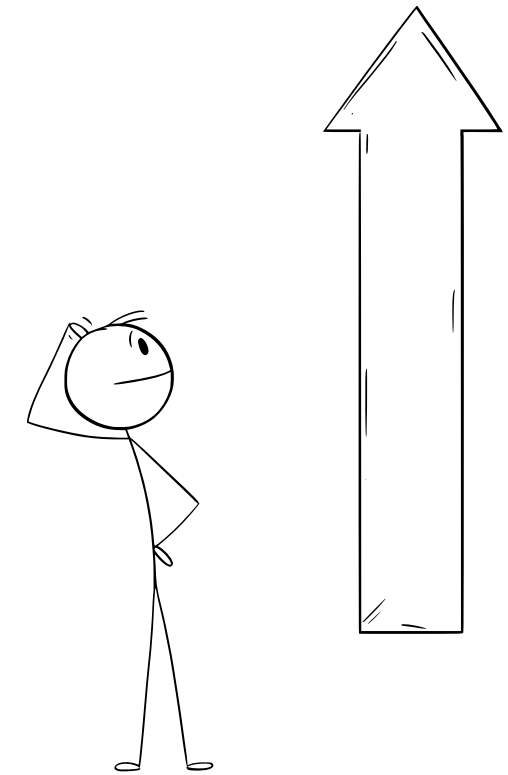
Types of Cognitive Load



Intrinsic

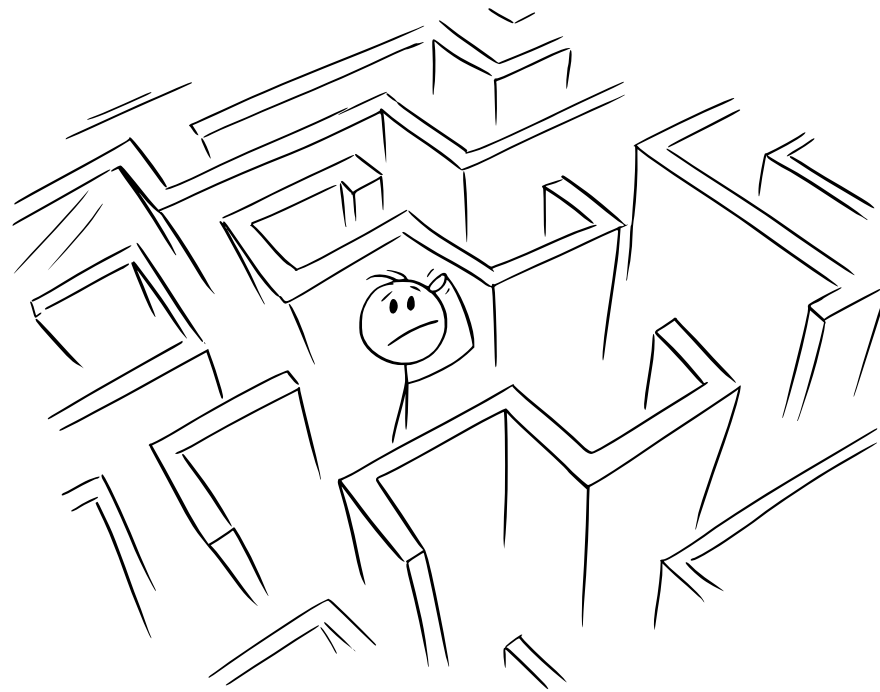


Extraneous



Germane

Types of Cognitive Load



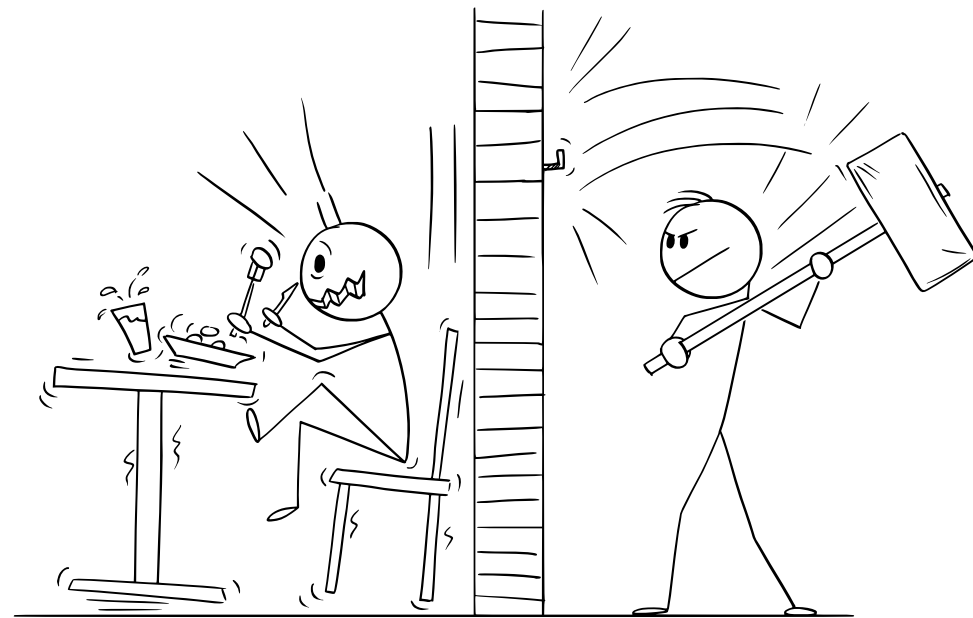
Intrinsic

The inherent difficulty of the subject matter itself, which can be influenced by a learner's prior knowledge.

Can't be avoided, but can be managed.

Types of Cognitive Load

The noise....



Extraneous

Unnecessary or redundant information and poor instructional design that does not aid learning and consumes working memory.

Types of Cognitive Load

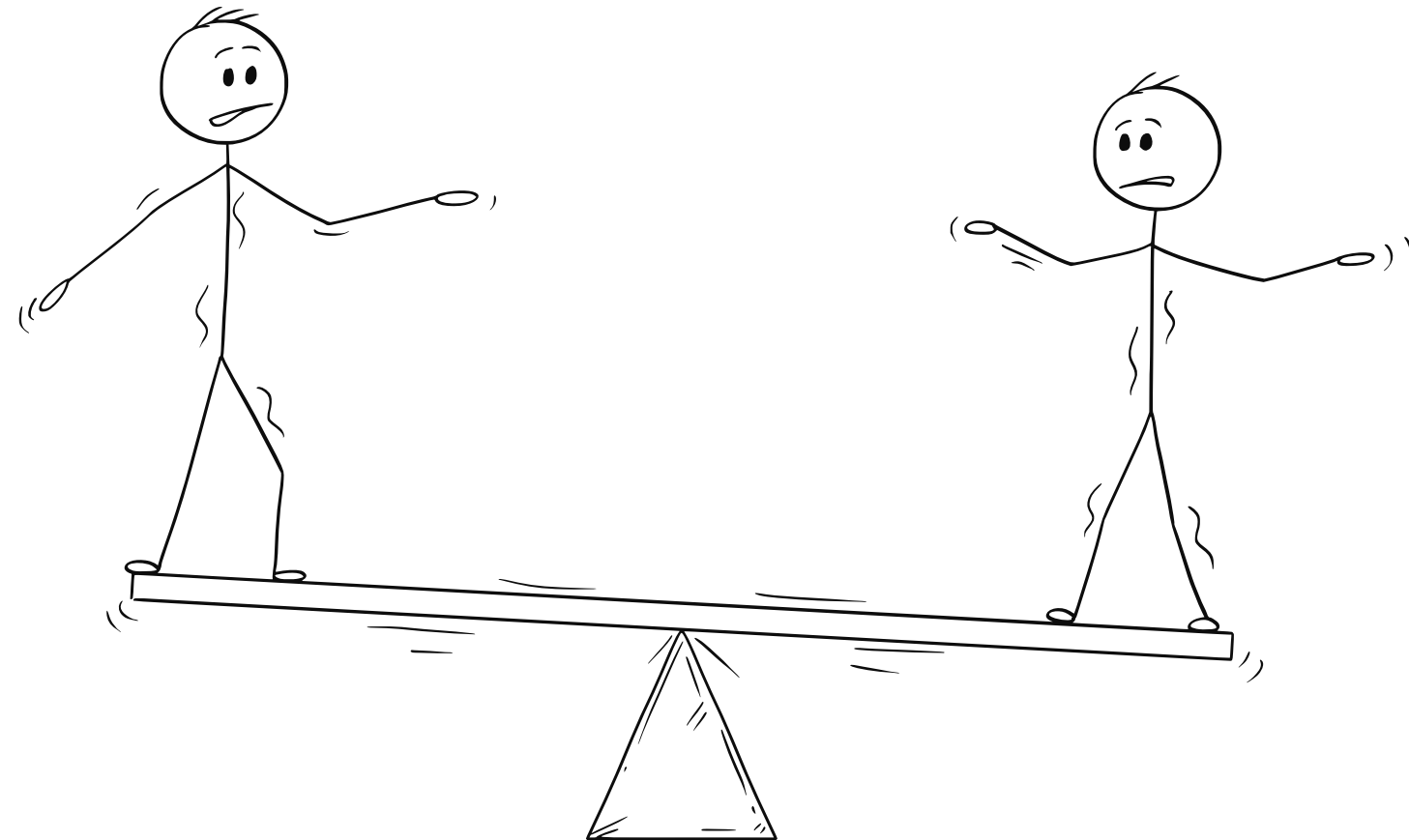


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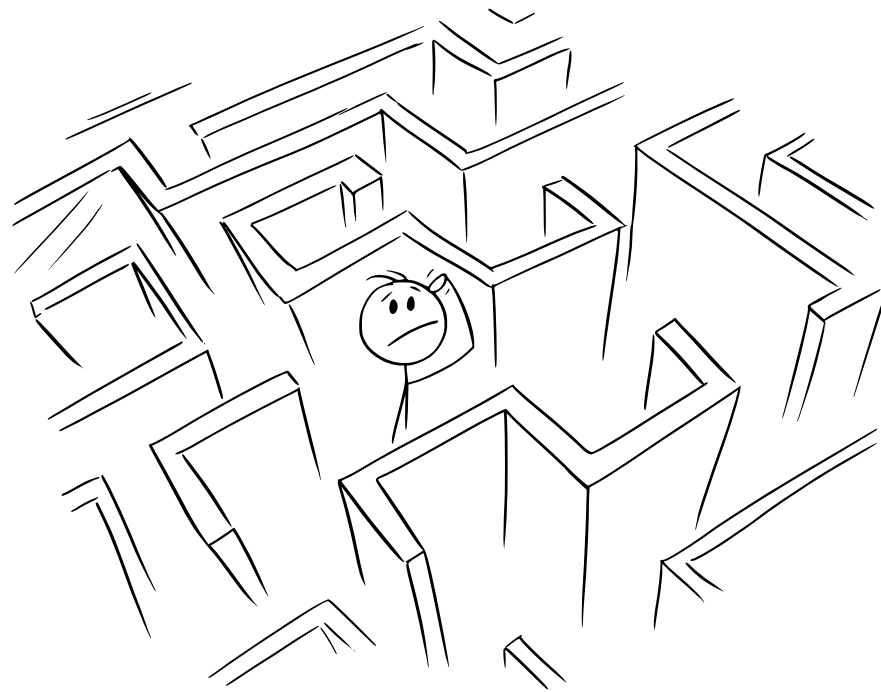
Deep processing of New
information.

The brainpower we use to learn
and grow.

MANAGING COGNITIVE LOAD

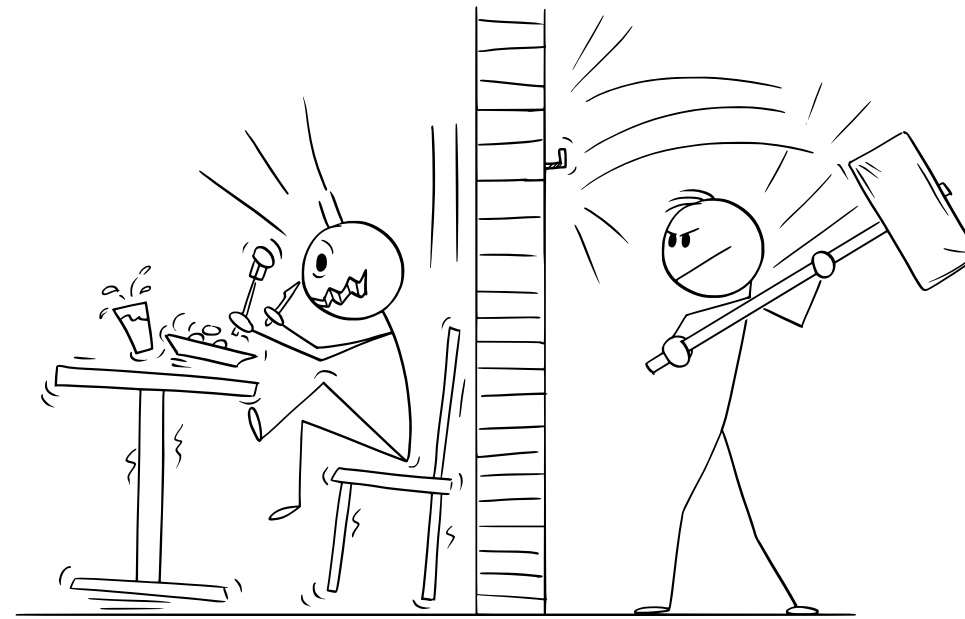


Managing Cognitive Load



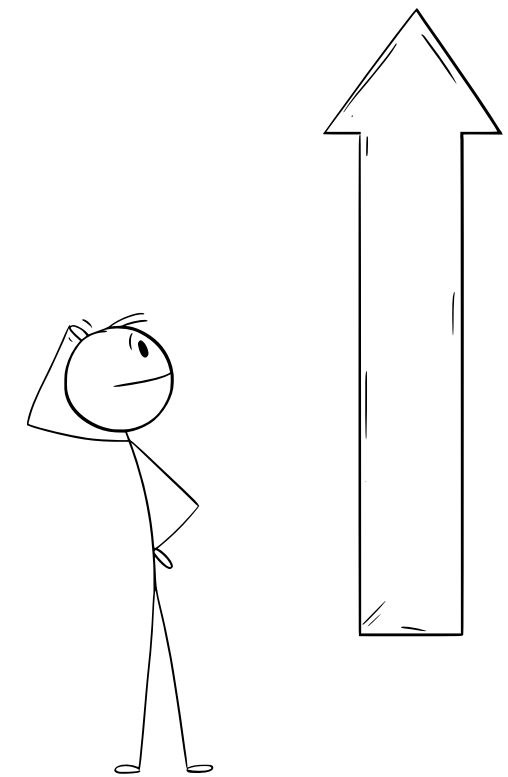
Intrinsic

Simplify



Extraneous

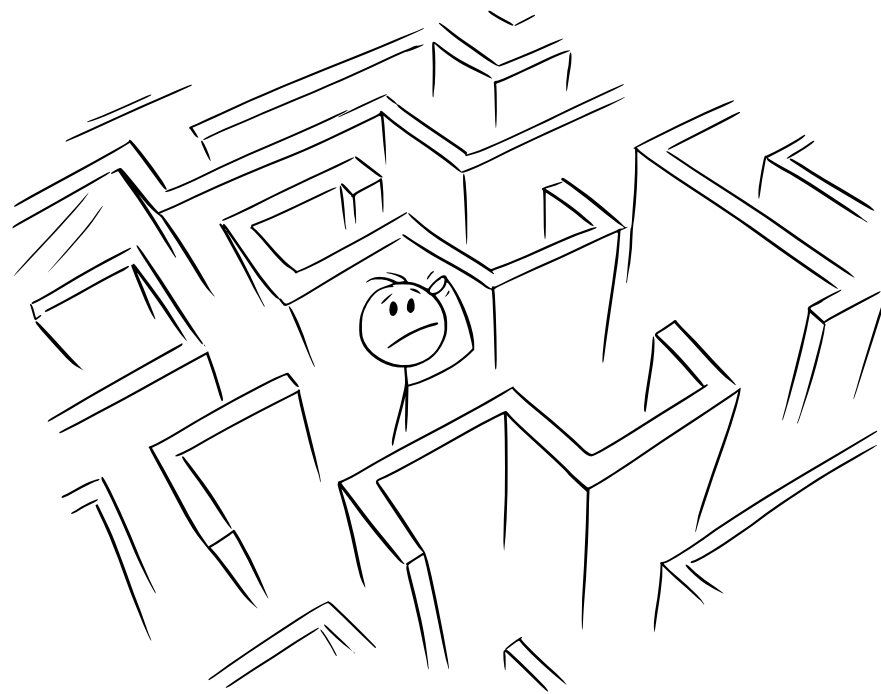
Reduce



Germane

Maximise

Managing Cognitive Load

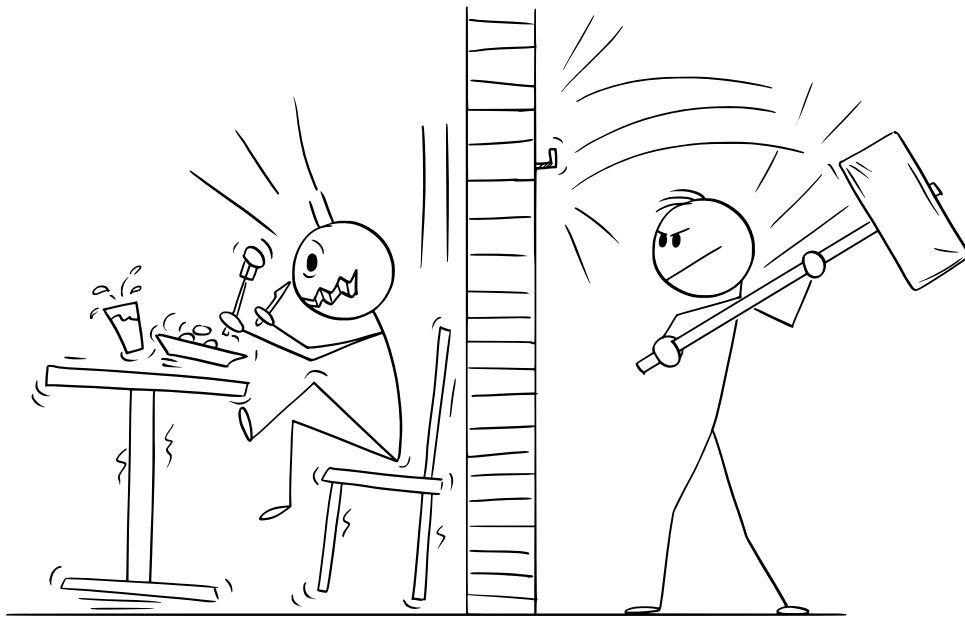


Intrinsic

Simplify

- Prioritisation frameworks (Eisenhower Matrix, MoSCoW)
- Clear goals & transparent roadmaps
- Service design & automation

Managing Cognitive Load

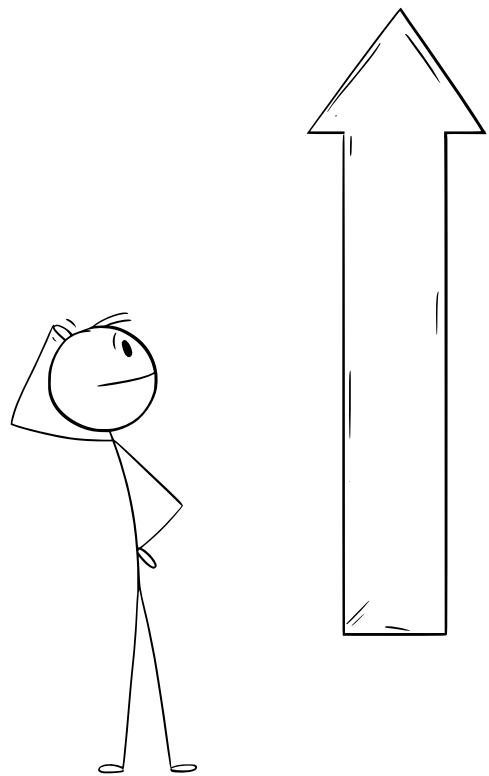


Extraneous

Reduce

- AI to handle repetitive tasks (ticket triage, chatbots, automation)
- Well-run 'Brilliant-basic' processes
- Streamlined tooling & dashboards

Managing Cognitive Load



Germane

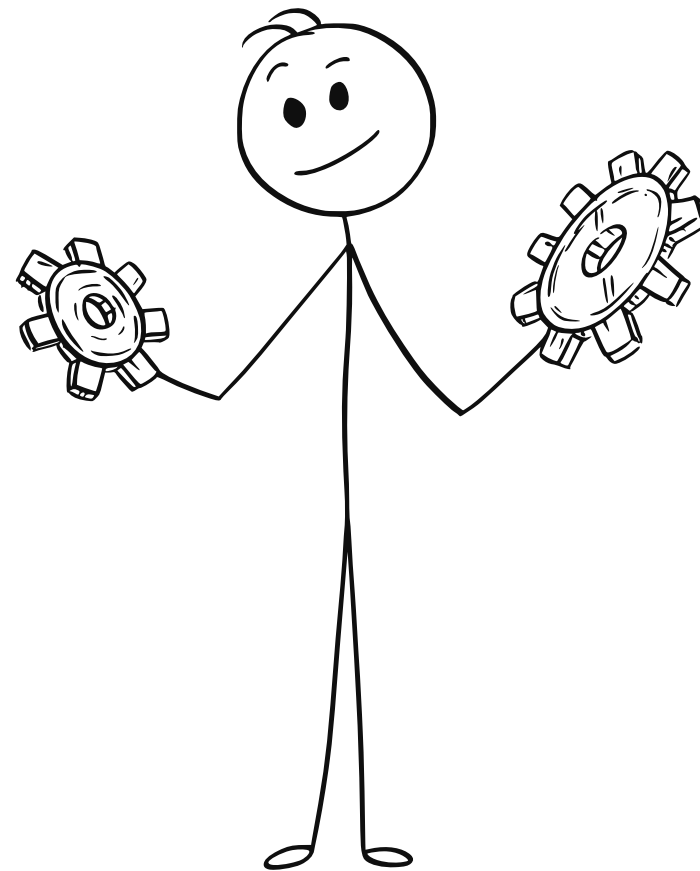
Maximise

- Psychological safety for experimentation & failure
- Retrospectives, post-incident reviews
- Training, knowledge sharing, mentoring

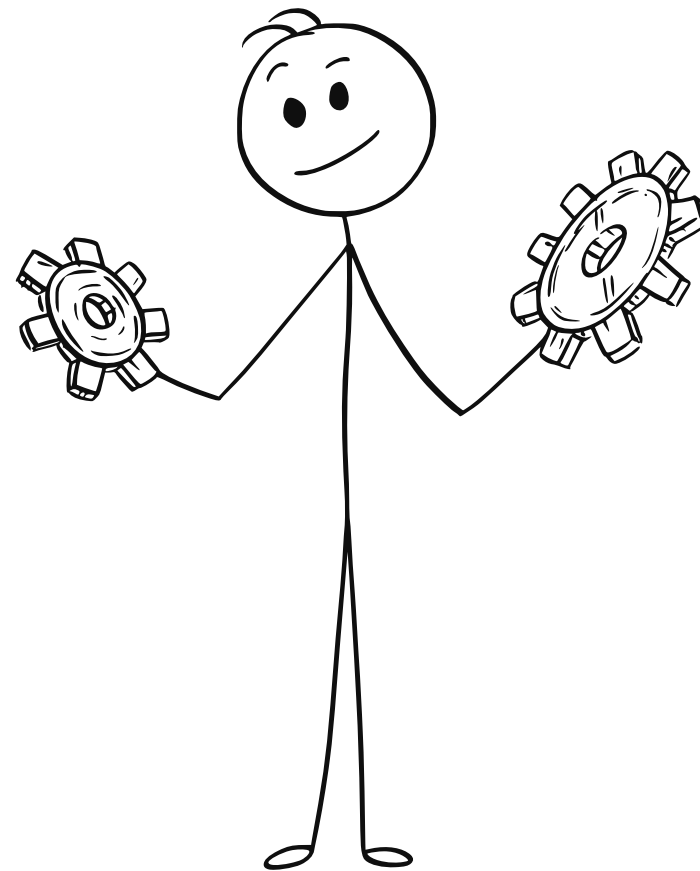
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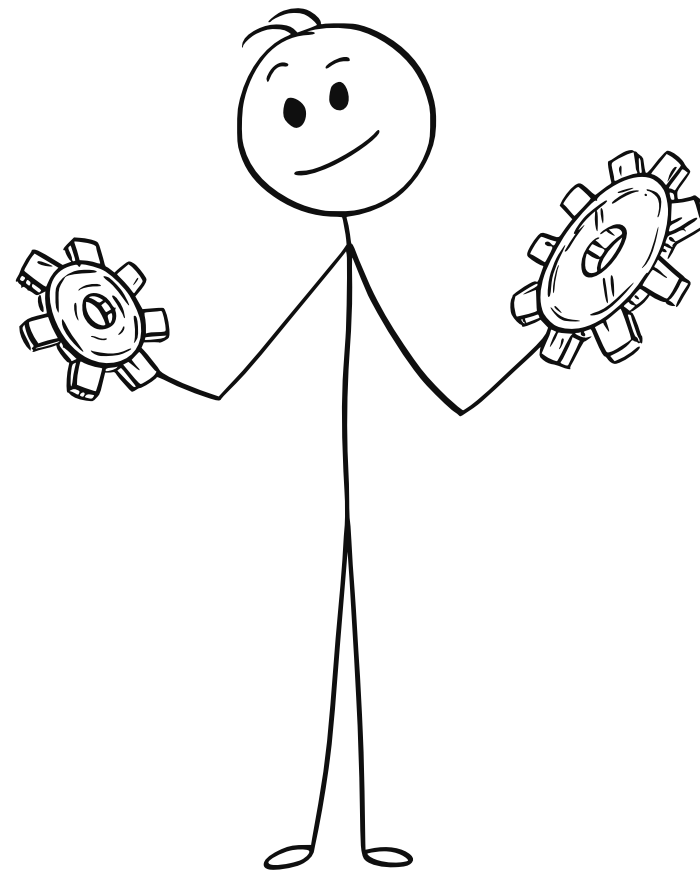
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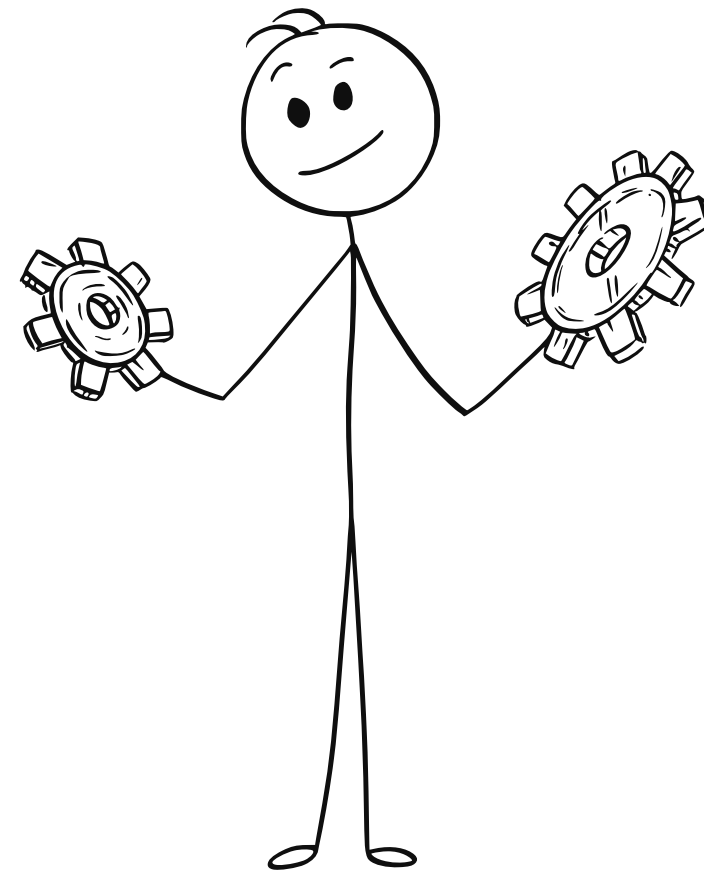
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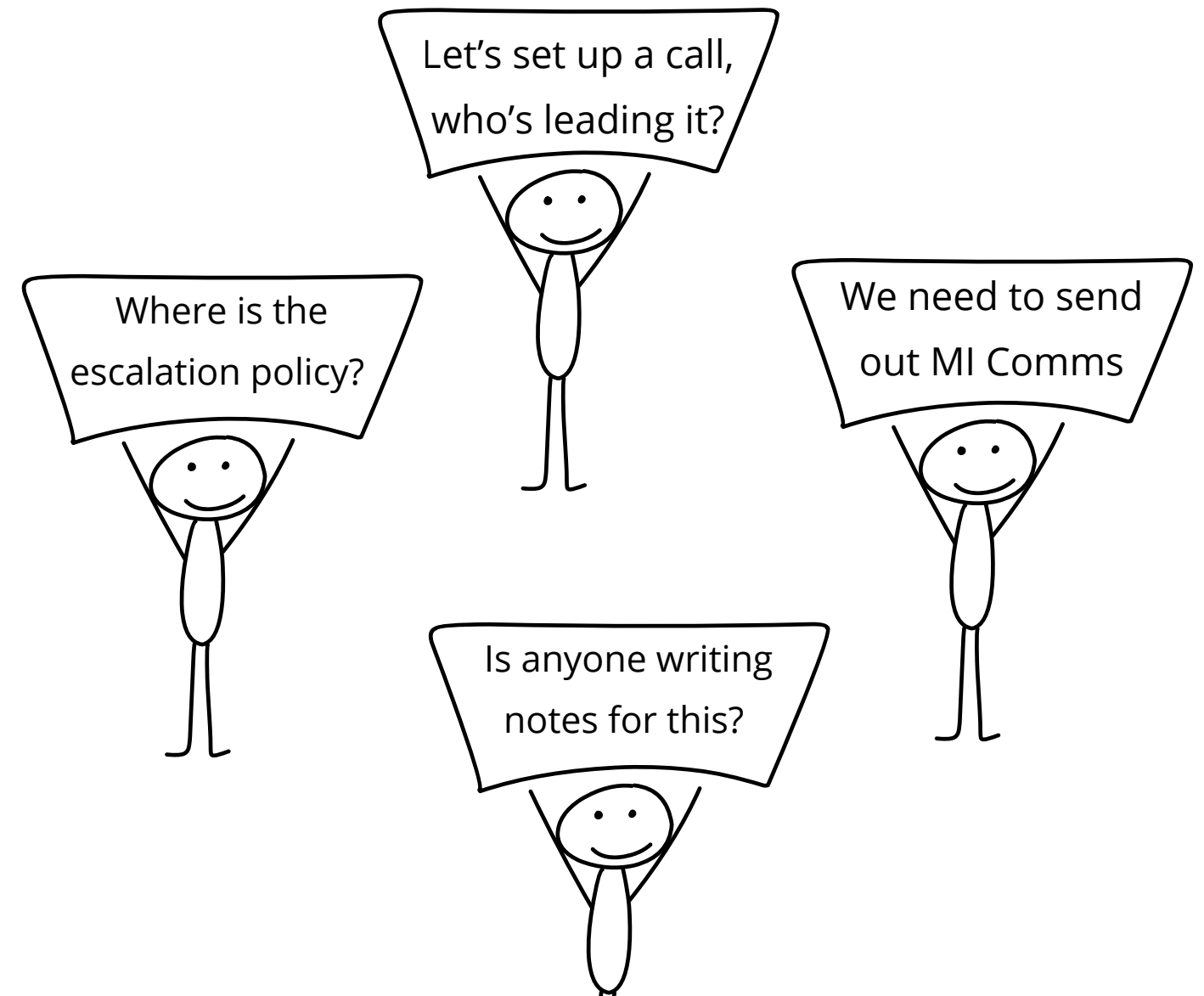
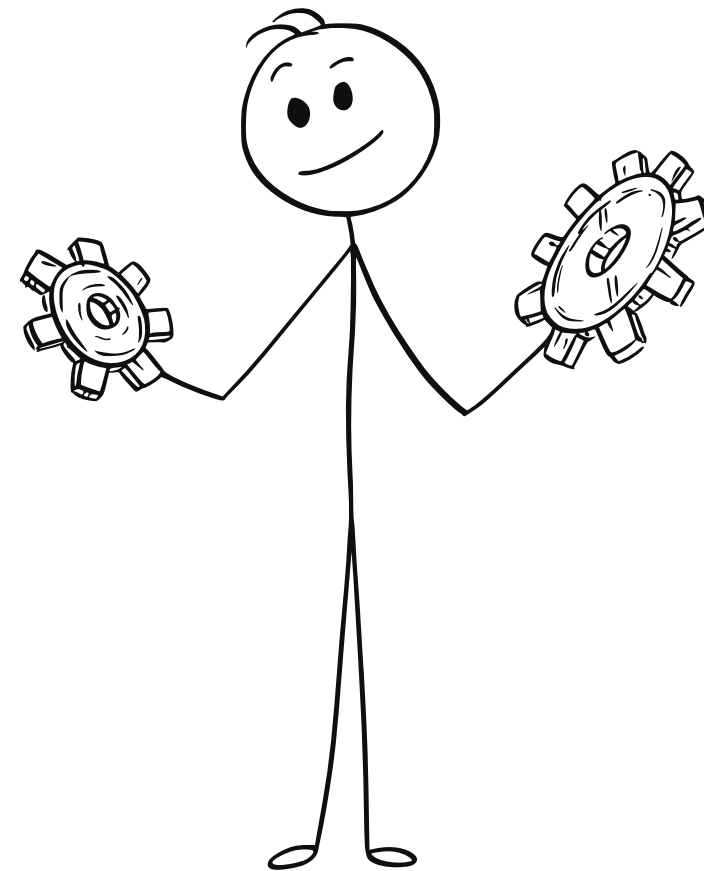
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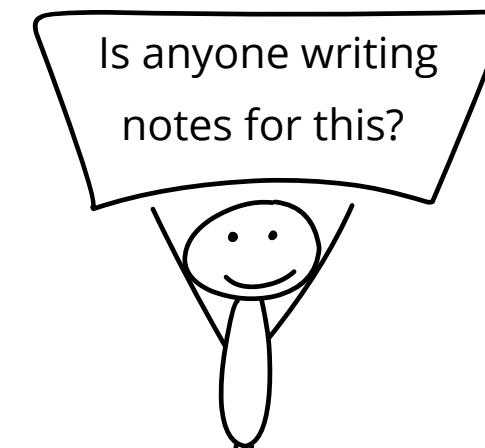
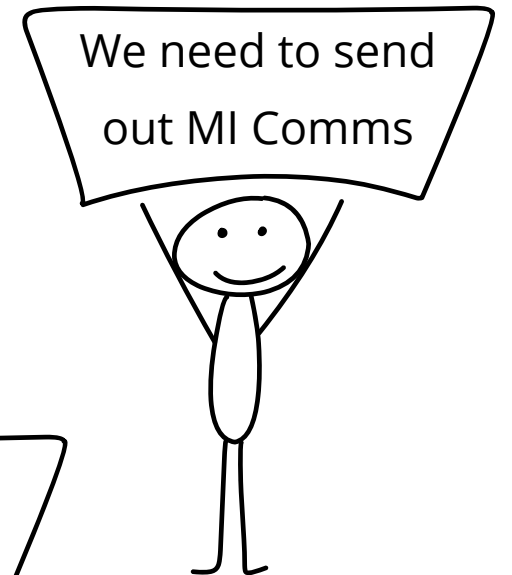
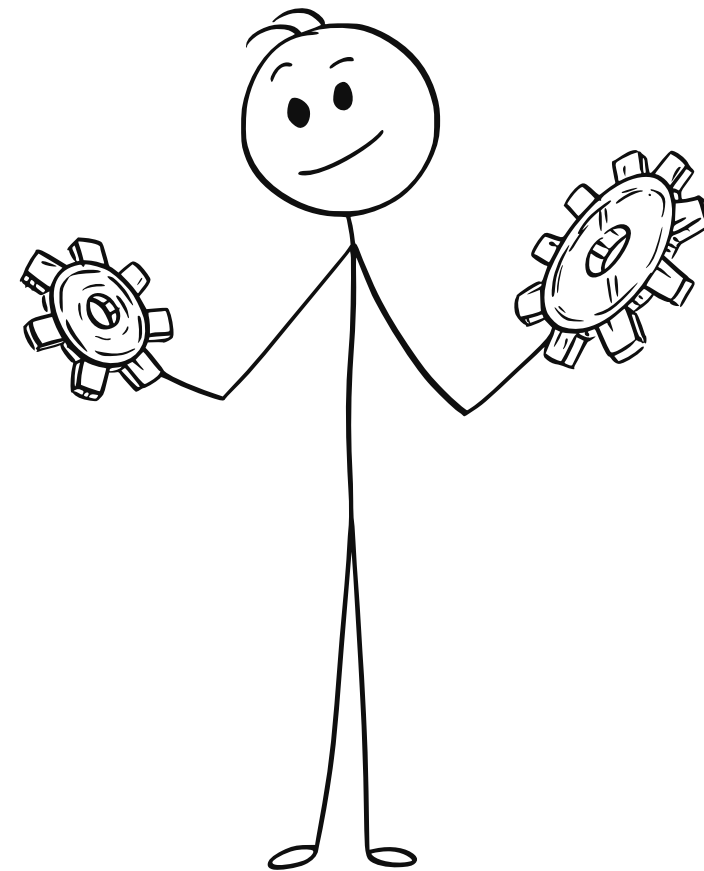
MAJOR INCIDENT SCENARIO



MAJOR INCIDENT SCENARIO



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MAJOR INCIDENT SCENARIO

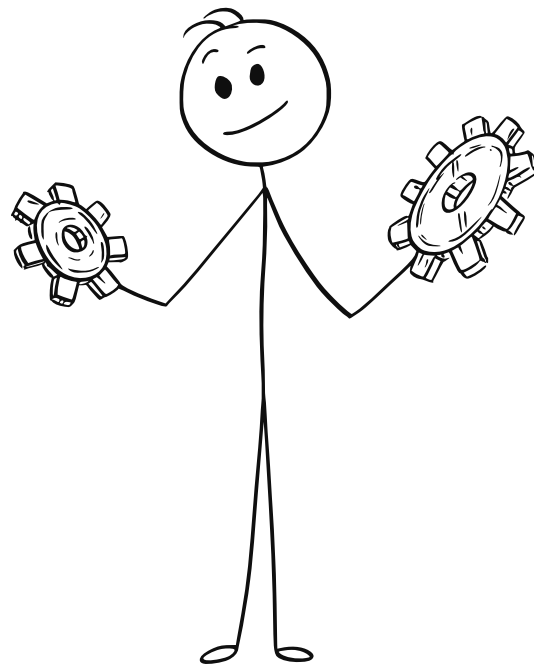


Time to Resolve increased

Lack of accountability

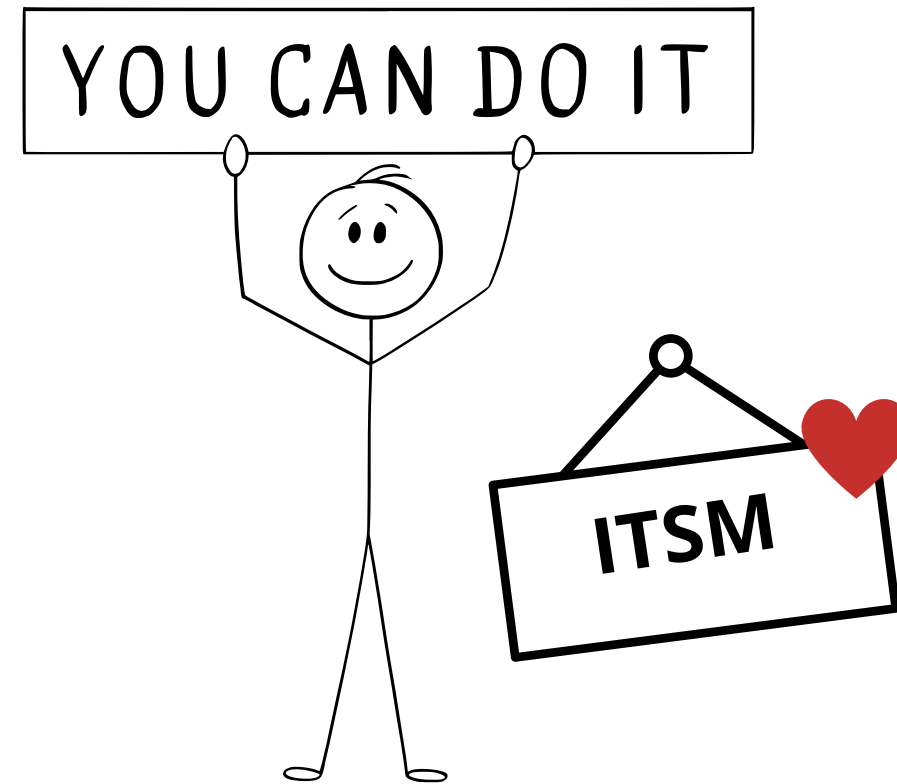
Poor Collaboration

MAJOR INCIDENT SCENARIO



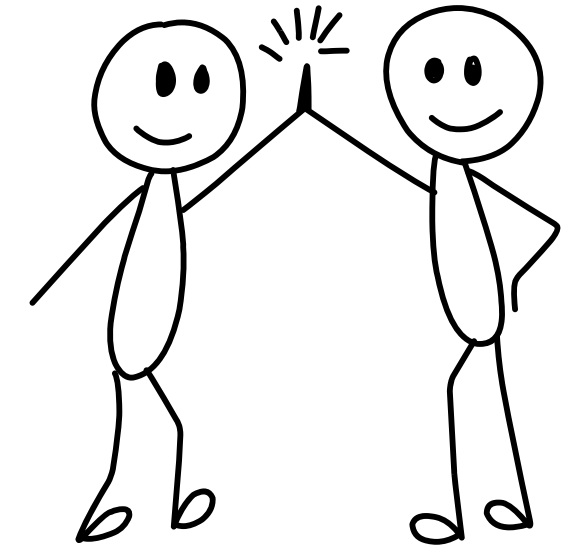
Intrinsic

Let those fixing the issue, fix the issue



Extraneous

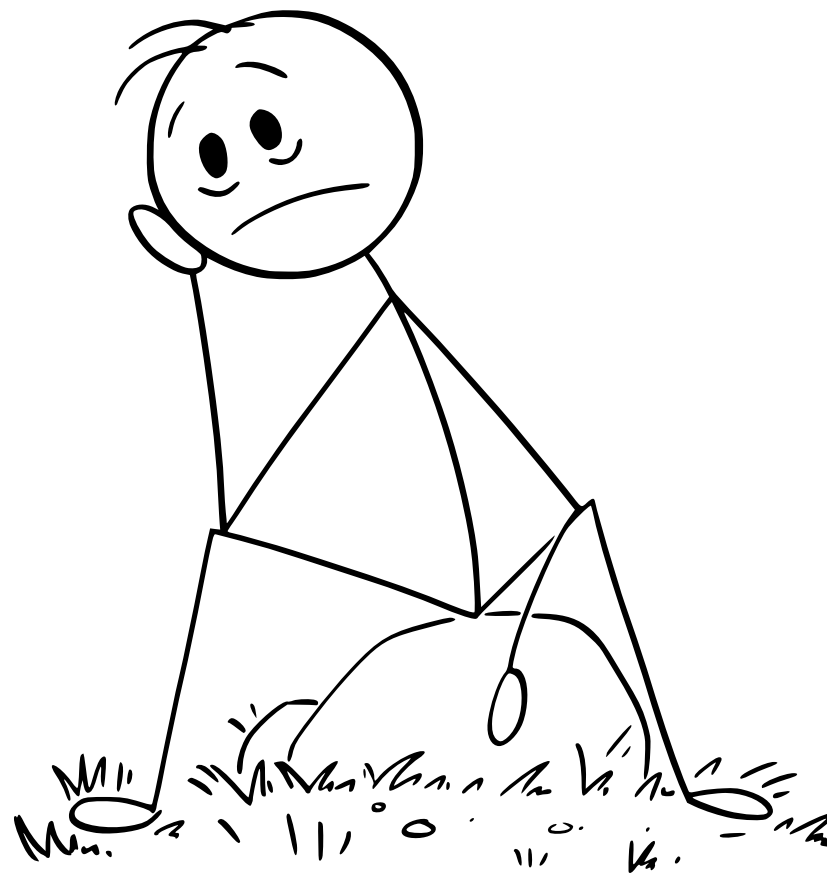
Minimise everything else for the Incident resolvers.



Germane

Have a strong PIR process, focused on learning.

**WHAT IF WE DONT GET
THIS RIGHT?**



Why it matters - Burnout

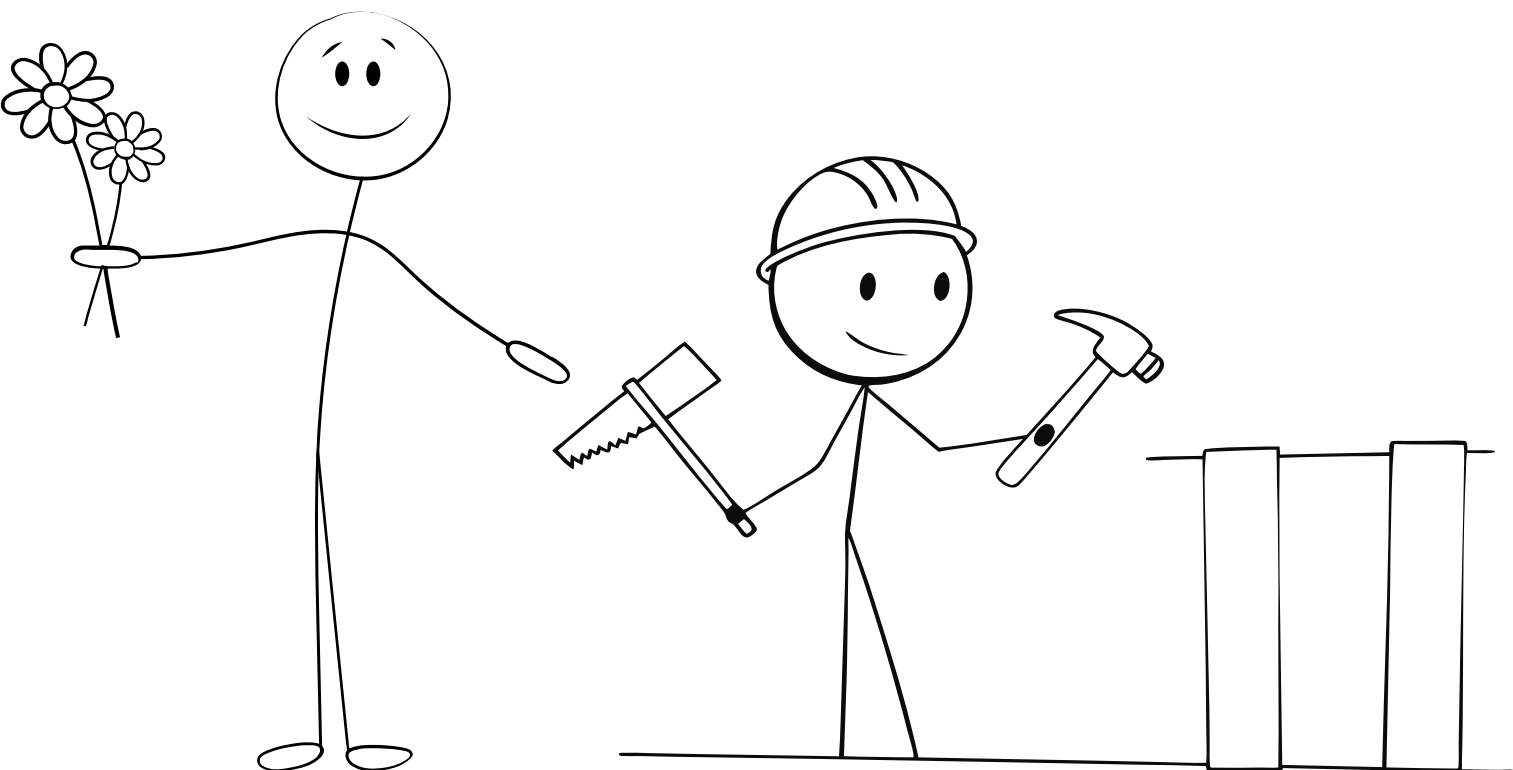
Burnout

A state of prolonged and overwhelming **physical, mental, and emotional exhaustion** caused by chronic stress, often from work but also from other life areas

UK Employment at a glance

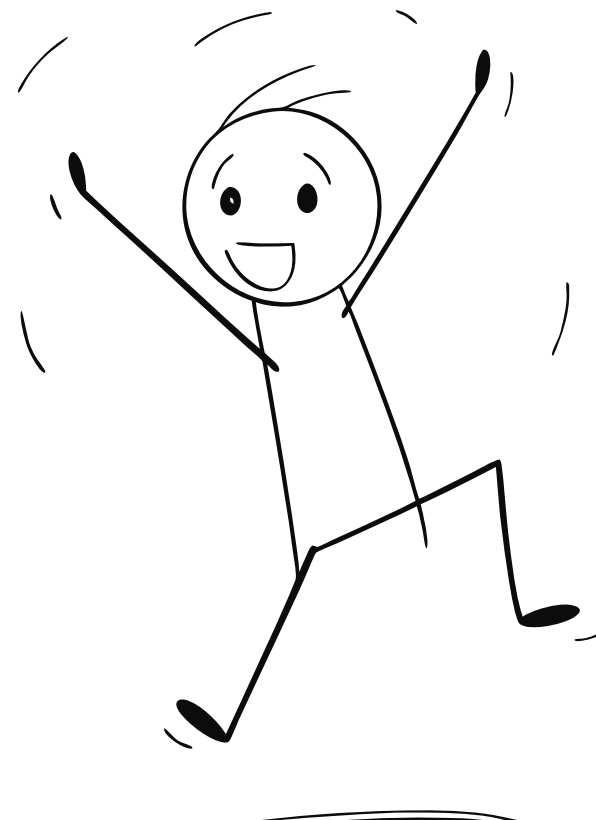
- 776,000 workers with work-related stress, depression or anxiety
- 6.4 million working days lost in 2023/24
- Stress, depression or anxiety = ~46% of ill health cases / 54% of sick days lost
- 74% of workers reported significant burnout symptoms
- 62% of tech workers say their job leaves them emotionally and physically drained
(TechUK Survey)

Why it matters to us & the organisation?



Wellbeing

Productivity Loss



Reputation & Morale



Turnover & Hiring Costs

THE ROLE OF ITSM

- Enablers not blockers
- Works in all three cognitive load types:



Intrinsic Load

(Task Complexity)

- Strong observability practices
- Knowledge management availability
- Well-designed services from the start

Extraneous Load

(The Noise)

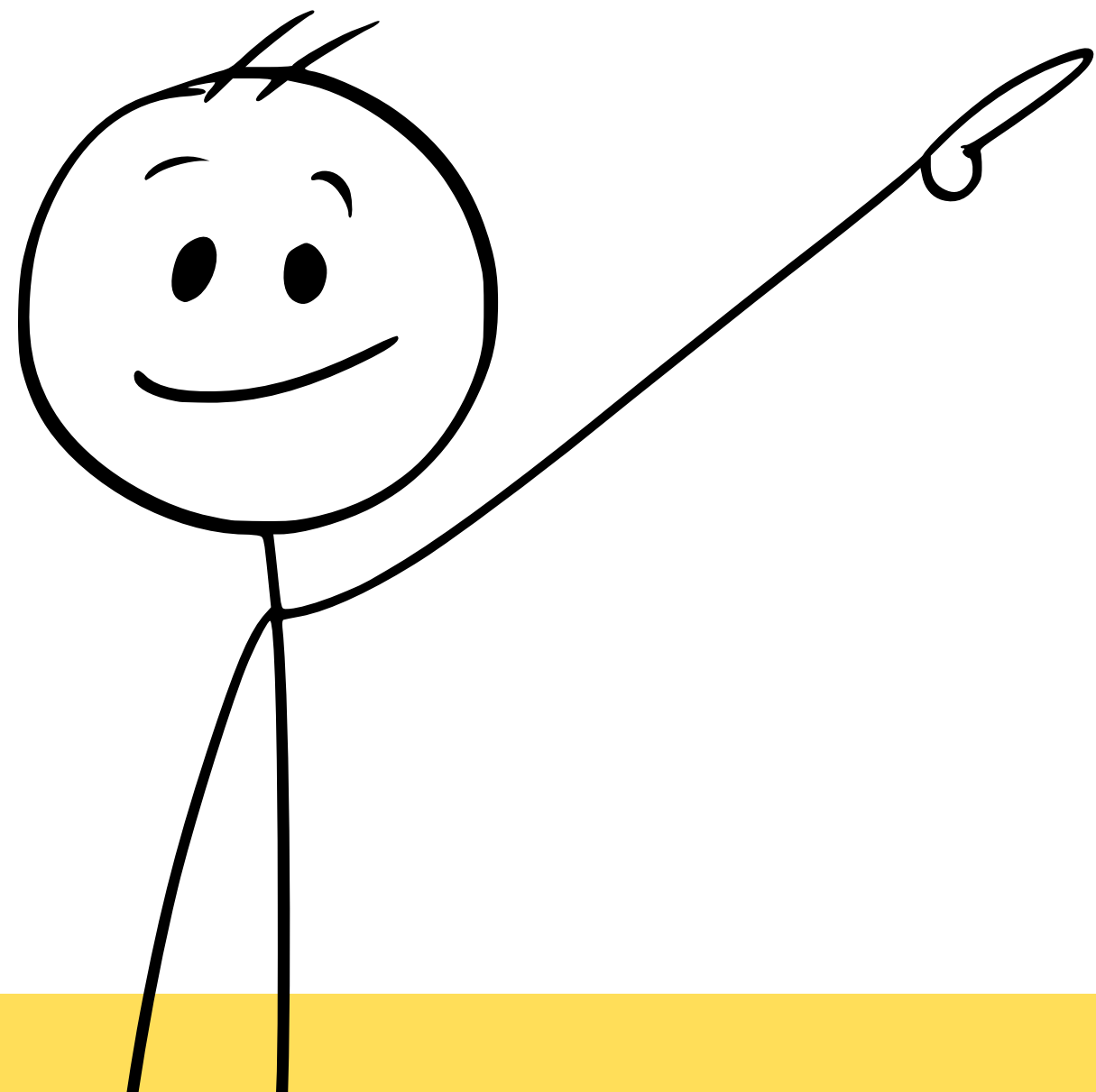
- Owns processes (e.g. Major Incident, Change)
- Clear communication & coordination
- Removes unnecessary friction from teams

Germane Load

(Learning & Growth)

- Creates a culture of continuous learning
- Retrospectives & lessons learned
- Supports training & development practices

**Don't stop being
busy, be busy in
the right way!**



In Summary

Thank you &
ANY QUESTIONS?

